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inating account
of the nature and dignity of the vocation
to the intellectual life."—The Sign

The Intellectual Life

Its Spirit, Conditions, Methods

A. D. Sertillanges, O. P.

translated by Mary Ryan

A Newman Paperback

THE INTELLECTUAL LIFE

Its Spirit, Conditions, Methods

by A. G. Sertillanges, O.P.

translated from the French by
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Foreword

Among the works of St. Thomas there is a letter to a certain Brother John, in which are enumerated *Sixteen Precepts for Acquiring the Treasure of Knowledge.*[1] This letter, whether it be authentic or not, must be looked at in itself; it is priceless; we should like to imprint its every word in the inmost being of the Christian thinker. We published it together with the *Prayers* of the same teacher, in which his religious thought is condensed and his soul revealed.[2]

We conceived the idea of commenting on the *Sixteen Precepts,* in order to link up with them things of which it is perhaps useful to remind men of study in our day. In practice, that method seemed rather restrictive; we have chosen to adopt a freer procedure; but the substance of this little volume is none the less entirely Thomistic; it will be found to contain what the master suggests, in the *Sixteen Precepts* and elsewhere, concerning the management of the mind.

1 They are given in Latin and English, with a commentary, in a lecture by Fr. Victor White, O.P., published by Blackfriars, Oxford, December 1944: *St. Thomas Aquinas, De Modo Studendi,* price 6d.

2 *Les Prières de Saint Thomas d'Aquin,* traduites et présentées par A.D. Sertillanges. Librairie de l'Art Catholique, 1920.

store, we cannot doubt the identity of the principles which, in the one process as in the other, make our intellectual activity fruitful.

For that reason we may hope to be useful to all.

CHANDOLIN
August 15th, 1920.

3 Translated into English under the title of *The Well-Springs*, by Stephen J. Brown, S.J., Burns, Oates & Washbourne, 1931.

deepest in me. I had had them in mind for a quarter of a century when they saw the light of day. I wrote them as one expresses one's essential convictions and pours out one's heart.

What makes me trust that they have struck home is assuredly their wide diffusion; but still more the testimony of innumerable letters: some thanking me for the technical help I gave to intellectual workers; others for the ardor that they said had been aroused in young or older hearts; the greater number for what seemed to the reader a revelation precious above all—that of the spiritual climate proper to the awakening of the thinker, to his evolution, his progress, his inspiration, his work.

That is indeed the principal thing. The mind governs everything; it begins, accomplishes, per-

self-will which is the state of grace of the intellectual worker. Without that you will do nothing, at least nothing worth while.

The intellectual is not self-begotten; he is the son of the Idea, of the Truth, of the creative Word, the Life-giver immanent in His creation. When the thinker thinks rightly, he follows God step by step; he does not follow his own vain fancy. When he gropes and struggles in the effort of research, he is Jacob wrestling with the angel and "strong against God."

Is it not natural, given these conditions, that the man of vocation should put away and deliberately forget his everyday man; that he should throw off everything of him: his frivolity, his irresponsibility, his shrinking from work, his material ambitions,

passes and returns not. Happy the man who holds himself ready not to miss, nay rather to bring about and to utilize, the miraculous encounter!

Every intellectual work begins by a moment of ecstasy; [1] only in the second place does the talent of arrangement, the technique of transitions, connection of ideas, construction, come into play. Now, what is this ecstasy but a flight upwards, away from self, a forgetting to live our own poor life, in order that the object of our delight may live in our thought and in our heart?

Memory itself has a share in this gift. There is an inferior memory, that of the parrot and not of the

[1] Because a man is lifted out of and above himself: Greek *ek-stasis*, out of one's ordinary foothold. (Tr. Note.) See pages 31, 133, 255.

lingering hesitation of youth, which is so often tormented and perplexed, we had to reach the discovery of ourself, the perception of that secret urge within us, which is directed towards some distant result of which we are not yet clearly conscious. Do you imagine that this is easy? Listening to oneself is a formula that amounts to the same thing as listening to god. It is in the creative Thought that our true being lies, our *self* in its authentic shape. Now this truth of our eternity, which dominates our present and augurs of our future, is revealed to us only in the silence of the soul—that is, in the exclusion of foolish thoughts which lead to a puerile and dissipating indulgence in distraction,[1] in the

[1] *Divertissement.* See note on page 216.

we are close to the eternally true, far from the covetous and passionate self.

And when we have done our part, results and the measure of them will demand the same virtue of acceptance, the same selflessness, the same peace in a Will that is not ours. One achieves what one can, and we need to judge our own capacity so as not on the one hand to underestimate it, or, inversely, not to exceed in the direction of pretentiousness and vain conceit. Whence comes this self-judgment, if not from a steady glance at the impersonally true, and from submission to its verdict, even if it cost us an effort or a secret disappointment?

Great men seem to us men of great boldness; in reality they are more obedient than others. The

The man who has not the sense of true greatness is easily exultant or easily depressed, sometimes both together. It is because the ant does not consider the giant beetle that he looks down on the tiny gnat; and it is because the walker does not feel the wind from the heights that he lingers on the mountain slopes. Always conscious of the immensity of the true and of the slenderness of our resources, we shall not undertake anything beyond our power, but we shall go on to the limit of our power. We shall rejoice, then, in what has been given us in our measure.

It is not a question of mere measuring. The real point of the remark lies in this, that weak work or pretentious work is always bad work. A life with too ambitious an aim or one content with too low

little; how can they be resisted without single-minded attachment to the truth, and without complete self-forgetfulness? When the world does not like you it takes its revenge on you; if it happens to like you, it takes its revenge still by corrupting you. Your only resource is to work far from the world, as indifferent to its judgments as you are ready to serve it. It is perhaps best if it rejects you and thus obliges you to fall back on yourself, to grow interiorly, to watch yourself, to deepen yourself. These benefits are in the measure in which we rise above self-interest, that is, in which interest centers on the one thing necessary.

Are we perhaps ourselves exposed to the temptation of disparaging, envying, unjustly criticizing others, of disputing with them? We must then re-

own good fortune.

A different sort of good fortune may tempt us: that of external success, though, to tell the truth, that is nowadays very rare in the case of a true intellectual. The public as a whole is vulgar and likes only what is vulgar. Edgar Allan Poe's publishers said that they had to pay him less than others because he wrote better than others. I once knew a painter to whom a picture dealer said, "You need some lessons."

"? . . ."

"Yes, to learn not to paint so well."

The man whose heart is set on perfection does not understand that sort of language; he does not consent at any price, or in any form, to cultivate

tion, without a boundless love for the truth that gives judgment?

That readiness to admit error is offset, it is true, by an uncompromising adherence to our fundamental persuasions, to those intangible intuitions that are at the bottom of our effort and of our very self-criticism. We cannot build on nothing, and the retouches of the workman do not reach down to the first foundations. What we have won by study and considered carefully must be guarded against unjustified second thoughts and scruples. This is demanded by the love of truth of which we have spoken; it is demanded by the same selflessness, which makes us interest ourselves in what is beyond us and yet has taken up its abode in our conscious-

not work in depth, nor that we must neglect that broad culture which is a condition of depth in any domain; but that a sure devotion to the true, without personal passion, without loss of balance, is the corrective of excess.

There is another line of defense against hastiness in our judgments and in the development of our work. One is not dazzled, when one loves the truth, by a brilliant idea set in an aureole of commonplaces. That kind of thing does not yield a real result. The most mediocre mind may hit on an idea, like a rough diamond or a pearl. What is difficult is the cutting of the idea, and, above all, its setting into a jewel of truth which will be the real creation.

"Among the hasty readers of books," says Ramon Fernandez amusingly, "I am inclined to

to know how to give radiance to an idea by means of its twilight background. It is a further secret to preserve its power of convergence in spite of this radiating quality.

Does failure threaten us or have we already experienced it? This is the time to take refuge in that immutable, unconditional devotion to truth which inspired our effort. "My brain has become my refuge," writes Charles Bonnet. But higher than the brain is the object of its devotion, and that is a very much safer refuge. Even at the cost of suffering, creation is a joy; and, beyond creation, veneration for the idea whence it comes.

Besides, as Foch said, "It is with remainders that battles are won." You have failed in something now, which will prepare you to succeed in something else

that distant stars compel it to turn its eyes to the sky. Reason ambitions only a world; faith gives it infinity.

I do not want further to lengthen this discourse. What it contains will necessarily be repeated, since its purpose is to show where the All is to be found.

I have pleaded the claims of that All with an inadequacy of which I am fully conscious and for which I crave pardon. I earnestly wish that my suggestions concerning it, weak as they are, may inspire others to praise it better and to serve it more ardently.

A. G. SERTILLANGES

December, 1934.

in it. Perhaps it will be the central conception that our every effort to reach reality is an approach to the great primal Truth; perhaps the stimulating assurance that the individual vocation is always unique and necessary, for "God does not repeat Himself," or the encouraging doctrine of work "in joy"; perhaps detailed help towards living by these principles.

The Italian witticism *translator, traitor* is a warning. Indeed the translator should be a good craftsman, like the artist-craftsman praised in Ecclesiasticus, who "laboreth night and day . . . and by his continual diligence varieth the figure: he shall give his mind to the resemblance of the picture, and by his watching shall finish the work." Accordingly *quod potui feci.* No pains have been spared to re-

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hold happily in reserve, as a supplement of their activity and as a reward, the development and deepening of their mind.

I say the deepening, in order to set aside the idea of a superficial tincture of knowledge. A vocation is not fulfilled by vague reading and a few scattered writings. It requires penetration and continuity and methodical effort, so as to attain a fulness of development which will correspond to the call of the Spirit, and to the resources that it has pleased Him to bestow on us.

This call is not to be taken for granted. To start precipitately on a road which one could not tread with a firm step would be merely to prepare the way for disillusionment. Everyone has the duty to work; and after a first early and toilsome training

only its slaves.

This way of life must not be entered on without long self-examination. The intellectual vocation is like every other: it is written in our instincts, in our powers, in a sort of inner impulse of which reason must judge. Our dispositions are like the chemical properties which determine, for every body, the combinations into which that body can enter. A vocation is something that cannot be had for the asking. It comes from heaven and from our first nature. The whole point is to be docile to God and to oneself as soon as they have spoken.

Understood in this sense, Disraeli's saying that you may do what you please, provided it really pleases you, contains a great meaning. Our liking, if correlated to our fundamental tendencies and to

Every life or one of His members is a characteristic moment of His duration; every individual man and Christian is an instance, incommunicable, unique, and therefore necessary, of the extension of the "spiritual body." If you are designated as a light bearer, do not go and hide under the bushel the gleam or the flame expected from you in the house of the Father of all. Love truth and its fruits of life, for yourself and for others; devote to study and to the profitable use of study the best part of your time and your heart.

All roads but one are bad roads for you, since they diverge from the direction in which your action is expected and required. Do not prove faithless to God, to your brethren and to yourself by rejecting a sacred call.

wise there would be no real obedience to your vocation. Many people would like to possess knowledge! A vague aspiration turns the eyes of the multitude towards horizons that the greater number admire from afar off, as the victim of gout or asthma looks up to the eternal snows. To get something without paying for it is the universal desire; but it is the desire of cowardly hearts and weak brains. The universe does not respond to the first murmured request, and the light of God does not shine under your study lamp unless your soul asks for it with persistent effort.

You are consecrated by your vocation. Will what truth wills; consent for the sake of truth to bestir yourself, to take up your abode within its proper

ways the heir of the past; the penalty for neglecting, at the right time, to prepare it, is to live on the surface of things. Let each one think of that, while thinking may be of some avail.

How many young people, with the pretension to become workers, miserably waste their days, their strength, the vigor of their intelligence, their ideal! Either they do not work—there is time enough!—or they work badly, capriciously, without knowing what they are nor where they want to go nor how to get there. Lectures, reading, choice of companions, the proper proportion of work and rest, of solitude and activity, of general culture and specialization, the spirit of study, the art of picking

What I have just said is true of everyone. But I apply it especially to those who know that they have at their disposal only a part of their life, the least part, in which to give themselves to the labors of the mind. They, more than others, must be men consecrated by their vocation. What they cannot spread out over all their years, they must concentrate in a small space. The special asceticism and the heroic virtue of the intellectual worker must be their daily portion. But if they consent to this double self-offering, I tell them in the name of the God of truth not to lose courage.

If genius is not necessary for production, still less is it necessary to have entire liberty. What is more, liberty presents pitfalls that rigorous obligations may help us to avoid. A stream narrowly hemmed-

poor drudging tortoise, he does not dawdle, he persists, and in a few years' time he will have outstripped the indolent hare whose agile movements were the envy of his own lumbering gait.

The same is true of the isolated worker, deprived of intellectual resources and stimulating society, buried in some little provincial spot, where he seems condemned to stagnate, exiled far from rich libraries, brilliant lectures, an eagerly responsive public, possessing only himself and obliged to draw solely on that inalienable capital.

He must not lose courage either. Though he have everything against him, let him but keep possession of himself and be content with that. An ardent heart has more chance of achieving something than a crammed head abusing the opportunities of great

themselves, at need, the wherewithal to do without such fortunate help. As to the public, if it sometimes stimulates, it often disturbs, scatters the mind; and by going to pick up two pennies in the street, you may lose a fortune. An impassioned solitude is better, for there every seed produces a hundredfold, and every ray of sunlight suffuses the whole landscape with autumnal gold.

St. Thomas of Aquin, as he was coming to settle in Paris and descried the great city in the distance, said to the brother who was with him: "Brother, I would give all that for the commentary of Chrysostom on St. Matthew." When one feels like that, it does not matter where one is nor what resources one has, one is stamped with the seal; one is of the

purposes. Most great men followed some calling. Many have declared that the two hours I postulate suffice for an intellectual career. Learn to make the best use of that limited time; plunge every day of your life into the spring which quenches and yet ever renews your thirst.

Do you want to have a humble share in perpetuating wisdom among men, in gathering up the inheritance of the ages, in formulating the rules of the mind for the present time, in discovering facts and causes, in turning men's wandering eyes towards first causes and their hearts towards supreme ends, in reviving if necessary some dying flame, in organizing the propaganda of truth and goodness? That is the lot reserved for you. It is

by his call must not be an isolated unit. Whatever be his position, however alone or hidden we suppose him to be materially, he must not yield to the lure of individualism, which is a distorted image of Christian personality.

As life-giving as is solitude, so paralyzing and sterilizing is isolation.

By being only a soul, one ceases to be a man, Victor Hugo would say. Isolation is inhuman; for to work in human fashion is to work with the feeling for man, his needs, his greatness, and the solidarity which binds us closely together in a common life.

A Christian worker should live constantly in the universal, in history. Since he lives with Jesus Christ he cannot separate times, nor men, from

parently abstract, the loftiest, is also the most practical. Every truth is life, direction, a way leading to the end of man. And therefore Jesus Christ made this unique assertion: "I am the Way, the Truth, and the Life."

Work always then with the idea of some utilization, as the Gospel speaks. Listen to the murmur of the human race all about you; pick out certain individuals of certain groups whose need you know, find out what may bring them out of their night and ennoble them; what in any measure may save them. The only holy truths are redeeming truths; and was it not in view of our work as of everything else that the Apostle said: "This is the will of God, your sanctification?"

Jesus Christ needs our minds for His work, as on

equal distance, it is not the same with the ages and with us, who dwell on the circumference. We are here at a given point on the mighty wheel, not elsewhere. If we are here, it is because God has placed us here. Every moment of duration concerns us, and every age is our neighbor, as well as every man; but the word "neighbor" is a relative word to which the wisdom of Providence attaches a precise meaning for each of us, and to which each of us, in submissive wisdom, must also attach a precise meaning.

Here I am, a man of the 20th century, living in a time of permanent drama, witnessing upheavals such as perhaps the globe never before saw since the mountains rose and the seas were driven into their caverns. What have I to do for this panting,

a love of the past which turns away from present suffering, an esteem for the past which seems not to recognize the universal presence of God. Every age is not as good as every other, but all ages are Christian ages, and there is one which for us, and in practice, surpasses them all: our own. In view of it are our inborn resources, our graces of today and tomorrow, and consequently the efforts that we must make in order to correspond with them.

Let us not be like those people who always seem to be pallbearers at the funeral of the past. Let us utilize, by living, the qualities of the dead. Truth is ever new. Like the grass of morning, moist with glistening dew, all the old virtues are waiting to spring up afresh. God does not grow old. We must help our God to renew, not the buried past and the

lectuality, for, since it leads to our end, which is intellectual, virtue is equivalent to the supreme knowledge.

One could draw many things from that, everything indeed; for this primacy of the moral order involves the relative dependence of truth, of beauty, of harmony, of unity, of being itself with regard to morality, which is thus related to the first principle of all things.

But I prefer to follow a humbler path.

The qualities of character have a preponderant role in everything. The intellect is only a tool; the handling of it determines the nature of its effects. Properly to regulate the intelligence, is it not evident that qualities quite different from intelligence

the victim of its surroundings.

If then character makes shipwreck, one must expect the sense of the great truths to suffer. The mind, being no longer held in check, no longer finding its level, will start down some dangerous incline, and one knows that a small error in the beginning becomes great in the end. The force of logic may send to a more precipitous fall the man whose faculty of discernment finds no safeguard in his soul. That is the cause of so many sensational lapses, and of so many blunders with a spark of genius in them, among masters who have lost the true direction of life.

Life is a unity: it would be very surprising if we could give fullest play to one of its functions while

soil, one or other suffers; the soul grows anemic or the mind wilts. On the contrary, by feeding the mind on truth one enlightens the conscience, by fostering good one guides knowledge.

By practising the truth that we know, we merit the truth that we do not yet know. We merit it in the sight of God; we merit it also with a merit which brings its own reward; for all truths are linked together, and homage in act being the most decisive of all, when we pay that homage by living the truth of life, we draw near to the supreme light and to all that flows from it.[1] If I embark on the tributary, I reach the river, and then the sea.

[1] The virtue called truth, says St. Thomas, "is a certain truth according to which a man in word and deed shows

among which for this or for that purpose we select the desired instrument? We think "with our whole soul," declared Plato. Presently we shall go much farther, we shall say: with our whole being. Knowledge involves everything in us, from the vital principle to the chemical composition of the least cell. Mental disorders of every sort, states of delirium, hallucinations, asthenia and hypersthenia, inadaptation to reality of whatever kind, prove that it is not the mind alone that thinks, but the man.

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himself as he is." The truth of life "is particularly so called according as a man in his life fulfils what he is ordained to by the divine intelligence." S.T.Ia, qu. 16, art. 4, ad 3. (Tr. Note.)

judgment in roundabout ways, of which Aristotle and many others after him have scrutinized the meanders.

All contemporary psychologists are in agreement here; the fact is plain to see, admitting of no doubt. The "psychology of the feelings" governs practice, but also, to a large extent, thought. Knowledge depends on the direction given to our passions and on our moral habits. To calm our passions is to awaken in ourselves the sense of the universal; to correct ourselves is to bring out the sense of the true.

Carry your analysis further. What are the enemies of knowledge? Plainly, lack of intelligence; there-

[1] VII Physic., lib. 6.

and his environment, but he will reach the level of his own gifts, of his own destiny.

We must notice that all the faults just mentioned bring one another more or less in their train; they intersect, they ramify, they are with regard to love of the good or contempt for the good what intersecting streamlets are to the spring. Purity of thought requires purity of soul; that is a general and undeniable truth. The neophyte of knowledge should let it sink deeply into his mind.

Let us rise higher, and speaking of springs, let us not forget the Supreme Spring. The surest metaphysic tells us that at the summit of things, the true and the good are not only connected, but are identical.

We must state for exactness' sake, that the good

the universal. This universal, which is at one and the same time the true and the good, cannot be honored as the true—we cannot enter into intimate union with it, discover its traces, and yield ourselves to its mighty sway—unless we recognize and serve it equally as the good.

Climb up the Great Pyramid by those giant steps that so exactly represent the ascent of the true: if you go up by the northern edge, can you reach the summit without getting nearer and nearer to the southern edge? To keep away from it would be to stay on the low levels; to turn away from it would be to go sideways and downwards. Similarly the genius of the true tends of itself to join the good; if it diverges it is at the expense of its upward impulse towards the summits.

eager impulse towards the great ends.

There is no question now of proving one's skill, of showing off the brilliance of one's powers, as of a jewel; one desires to get into communion with the radiant center of light and life; one approaches this center in its unity, as it is; one adores it, and renounces what is opposed to it in order to be flooded with its glory. Is not all that something like the meaning of the famous words: "Great thoughts come from the heart"? [1]

II

We see then that virtue in general is necessary for knowledge, and that the more moral rectitude

[1] One of Pascal's *Pensées*. In Pascal's language *coeur* means the whole man, with his experience, perceptions, intuitions (Tr. Note).

When I say to excess, I mean in both directions. To the virtue of studiousness, two vices are opposed: negligence on the one hand, vain curiosity on the other. We shall not speak here of the former; if it is not hateful to the reader when he comes to close this little book, it will be because he has grown weary on the way, or because we have managed the journey very badly. It is not the same with curiosity. This fault can creep in under cover of our best instincts, and vitiate them at the very moment that it pretends to satisfy them.

We have already referred to the ambitious ideas which pervert an intellectual vocation. Without going as far as that, ambition may injure studiousness, and hinder the usefulness of its results. An act

[1] St. Thomas, Summa Theologica, 2a, 2ae, qu. 167.

lent.

A country priest who devotes himself to his parishioners, a doctor who turns away from study to give help in urgent cases, a young man of good family who adopts a calling to help his people and in doing so has to turn his back on liberal studies, are not profaning the gift that is in them, they are paying homage to the True which is one and the same Being with the Good. If they acted otherwise they would offend truth no less than virtue, since, indirectly, they would be setting living truth at variance with itself.

One sees many men avid for knowledge who do not hesitate to sacrifice to it their strictest duties. They are not men of study, they are dilettanti.

Do not overload the foundation, do not carry the building higher than the base permits, or build at all before the base is secure: otherwise the whole structure is likely to collapse.

What are you? What point have you reached? What intellectual substructure have you to offer? These are the things that must wisely determine your undertaking. "If you want to see things grow big, plant small," say the foresters; and that is, in other words, St. Thomas's advice. The wise man begins at the beginning, and does not take a second step until he has made sure of the first. That is why self-taught men have so many weak points. They cannot, all by themselves, begin at the beginning. When they join a group already well on the

oneself truly and in remaining oneself! You have a part that only you can play; and your business is to play it to perfection, instead of trying to force fortune. Our lives are not interchangeable. Equally by aiming too high and by falling too low, one misses the path to the goal. Go straight ahead, in your own way, with God for guide.

To this necessary prudence St. Thomas adds the importance of not letting one's curiosity linger over earthly objects at the expense of the supreme object. Later on we shall draw from that a consequence which is important for the organization of our work; [1] but study must first of all leave room for worship, prayer, direct meditation on the things of God. Study is itself a divine office, an indirect

[1] Cf. below: The Field of Work: Comparative Study.

better if its spring is dried up.

The order of the mind must correspond to the order of things. In the world of reality, everything rises towards the divine, everything depends on it, because everything springs from it. In the effigy of the real within us, we can note the same dependence, unless we have turned topsy-turvy the true relations of things.

III

These dispositions will be secured, if apart from the exercises of piety which precede our study, we cultivate in work itself the spirit of prayer.

It is again St. Thomas who tells the passionate seeker after knowledge: *"Orationi vacare non*

knowledge?

Intelligence only plays its part fully when it fulfils a religious function, that is, when it worships the supreme Truth in its minor and scattered appearances.

Each truth is a fragment which does not stand alone but reveals connections on every side. Truth in itself is one, and the Truth is God.

Every truth is a reflection; behind the reflection, and giving it value, is the Light. Every being is a witness; every fact is a divine secret; beyond them is the object of the revelation, the hero witnessed to. Everything true stands out against the Infinite as against its background; is related to it; belongs to it. A particular truth may indeed occupy the

must venerate and love, keeping in contact with Him who thus embodies Himself. To separate this "body of God" from His Spirit is to abuse it; just as it is an abuse of Christ to see in Him the man only.

The Incarnation of Christ leads up to Communion, in which the Body, Blood, Soul, and Divinity of the Saviour are not separated; the quasi-incarnation of God in being, of eternal Truth in every separate instance of the truth, should also lead up to a heavenly ecstasy,[1] instead of our absent-minded investigations, and commonplace feelings of admiration.

Let us make up our minds to work under the

[1] See page ix of Preface, and pages 133, 255.

ing, he composed an admirable prayer for this use.[1] the child in knowledge, stammering in his effort at expression, most naturally looks to find the word he wants in the glance of God. But in knowledge itself, in Christian knowledge, we have the stepping-stool which raises us a little towards God, so that we return to study with soul enlightened and in a sense with the gifts of the prophet.

Everything that instructs us leads to God on a hidden byway. Every authentic truth is in itself eternal, and its quality of eternity turns us towards the eternity of which it is the revelation. Through nature and the soul, where can we go if not towards

[1] Cf. *Les Prières de saint Thomas d'Aquin;* Art Catholique, Paris.

meaning, are magnified, we see in them an episode of an immense spiritual happening. Even while we busy ourselves with some trifling thing, we feel ourselves dependent on truths in comparison with which the mountains are ephemeral; infinite Being and infinite duration enfold us, and our study is in very truth, "a study of eternity."

IV

We have already said that the doctrine of the composite nature of man forbids us to dissociate spiritual functions from even those corporal functions that are apparently least connected with pure thought. St. Thomas subscribes to this ironical notion of Aristotle: It is as ridiculous to say, the

ence on them, that the intellectual operation takes place. No one thinks, even if he is only utilizing an acquired idea, without calling up a whole complex of images, emotions, sensations, which are the culture medium of the idea.

When we want to awaken a thought in anyone, what are the means at our disposal? One only, to produce in him by word and sign states of sensibility and of imagination, emotion, and memory in which he will discover our idea and make it his own. Minds can only communicate through the body. Similarly, the mind of each one of us can only communicate with truth and with itself

1 Q.XIX *de Veritate,* art. 1, arg. 1.
2 *De Memoria,* lect. 1.
3 In II *De Anima,* lect. 19.

special life which in some aspects seems hardly human: let them place no hindrances in the way! Let us make ourselves a harmony of which the result will be the conquest of the true.

Now, there are here two considerations that must be faced without any human respect, although the first customarily startles spiritual persons who lack firmness of judgment.

First then, do not be ashamed to endeavor to keep well.

Some men of genius have had miserably bad health, and if it is God's will that that should happen to you, there is no more to be said. But if it is your own fault, it is a very guilty instance of tempting God. Are you quite sure that, following the ex-

1 St. Thomas, Q.XXVI *de Veritate* art. 3, ad 12m.

changes a man's character, his character changes his thoughts. If Leopardi had not been delicate and deformed, would he have been among the pessimists?

When, therefore, you resolve to live on a high level, do not imagine that it is taking a low stand to consider carefully, along with the activity of thought itself, all the particulars of its organic substructure. "A sound mind in a sound body" remains the ideal. The thinker has a special physiology; he must look after it and not hesitate to take expert advice on the matter.[1]

In any case, ordinary current rules must be

[1] Cf. Réveillé Parise: *Physiologie et hygiène des hommes livrés aux travaux de l'esprit,* 1881.

It is important to work in a position that gives free play to the lungs and does not compress the other organs. It is good from time to time to interrupt a spell of close application in order to breathe deeply, to stretch one's limbs in two or three rhythmic movements which relax the body and even prevent it from getting wrinkles. It has been found that slow and deep breaths, taken standing on tiptoe, with the window open, are still more effective as a relaxing agent. Neglect nothing where your health is concerned.

Every day you should take exercise. Remember the saying of an English doctor: "Those who do not find time to take exercise must find time to be ill." If you cannot take exercise in the open air, there

spend his life in the processes of digestion.

Pay still more attention to your sleep. Take neither too much nor too little. Too much will make you heavy, stupid, will slow up the blood and the power of thinking; too little will expose you to the risk of prolonging unduly the stimulation of work and dangerously superimposing strain upon strain. Watch yourself; in this question of sleep, as in that of food, find out how much you need and make a firm resolution to keep to it. There is no general rule.

To sum up, you must understand that, for an intellectual, care of the body, which is the instrument of the soul, is virtue and wisdom; St. Thomas

[1] J. P. Muller: *Mon système* (Ed. Lafitte).

effects, which indirectly are again diseases of the soul.

If one remains lazy, a glutton, a slave of the pillow and of the table; if one abuses wine, alcohol, tobacco; if one forgets oneself among unwholesome excitements, clinging to habits that are both debilitating and nerve-exhausting, to sins that are perhaps periodically forgiven, but of which the effects remain, how can one practice the hygiene of which we have urged the necessity?

A lover of pleasure is an enemy of his body and therefore quickly becomes an enemy of his soul. Mortification of the senses is necessary for thought, and can alone bring us to that *state of clear vision*

[1] *Contra Gentes,* III, cap. cxli.

which, in themselves, they form the better part, are among the most precious safeguards of your future.

towards your work, it is not enough to organize yourself within, definitely to settle your vocation and to make wise use of your powers; you must further arrange your exterior life, I mean in respect of its framework, its obligations, its contacts, its setting.

One word suggests itself here before any other: you must *simplify* your life. You have a difficult journey before you—do not burden yourself with too much baggage. Perhaps you are not absolutely free to do this, and so you think there is no use laying down rules. That is a mistake. Given the same external circumstances, a desire for simplification can do much, and what one cannot get rid of outwardly, one can always remove from one's soul.

ants. Much peace, a little beauty, certain conveniences that save time, are all that is necessary.

Slacken the tempo of your life. Receptions, visits that give rise to fresh obligations, formal intercourse with one's neighbors, all the complicated ritual of an artificial life that so many men of the world secretly detest—these things are not for a worker. Society life is fatal to study. Display and dissipation of mind are mortal enemies of thought. When one thinks of a man of genius, one does not imagine him dining out.

Do not let yourself get entangled in that mesh of occupations which little by little monopolizes time, thought, resources, powers. Conventions must not dictate to you. Be your own guide; obey your con-

your effort. The priest has the right to live by the altar and the man of study by his work; but one does not say Mass for money and one must not think and write for money.

Suppose you are of the number of those who have to earn their living otherwise than by the work they love, how will you preserve the few hours at your disposal if your life is over-full? You must reduce matter to the minimum, so as to lighten and liberate the spirit.

In this respect the wife of an intellectual has a mission that it is perhaps well to point out; it so often happens that she forgets it, and, instead of being Beatrice, succeeds in being merely a spendthrift and a chatterbox.

friction caused by lack of understanding in the sister soul is fatal to production; it keeps the mind in gnawing disquiet; it destroys all its soaring eagerness and all its joy; and how could the bird fly without its wings; how could bird or soul fly without their song?

Let the guardian spirit of the hearth be not its evil genius, but its muse. Having married a vocation, let her have the vocation also. Whether she achieve something herself or through her husband, what does it matter? She must still achieve since she is but one flesh with him who achieves. Without needing to be herself an intellectual, still less a woman of letters or a bluestocking, she can produce much by helping her husband to produce, com-

should serve to give the worker fresh courage rather than to lessen his resources. The little ones take much of you, and what good would they be if they did not now and then tease and tax you? But they hearten you just as much, and perhaps more; they can heighten your inspiration by mingling joy with it; they give you a love-lit reflection of nature and of man and thus defend you against the abstract; they bring you back to the real, about which their questioning eyes are waiting for an exact commentary from you. Their pure faces preach integrity, that sister of knowledge; and does not their readiness to believe, to hope, to have great dreams, and to expect everything from the fatherhood that guides them—does not this uplift you also, you man

point to safeguard, in view of which all the rest is necessary, is the wise provision of solitude, exterior and interior. St. Thomas is so deeply convinced of this that of sixteen counsels to the intellectual, he devotes seven to external contacts and to the retired life. "I want you to be slow in speaking and slow in going to the parlor." "Do not inquire at all about the actions of others." "Be polite to everyone" but "be familiar with none, for too much familiarity breeds contempt and gives matter for many distractions." "Do not busy yourself about the words and actions of those in the world." "Avoid useless outings above everything." "Love your cell, if you desire to be admitted to the wine-cellar."

those places where people speak, because in many words the spirit is poured out like water; by your amiability to all, purchase the right really to frequent only a few whose society is profitable; avoid, even with these, the excessive familiarity which drags one down and away from one's purpose; do not run after news that occupies the mind to no purpose; do not busy yourself with the sayings and doings of the world, that is with such as have no moral or intellectual bearing; avoid useless comings and goings which waste hours and fill the mind with wandering thoughts. These are the conditions of that sacred thing, quiet recollection. Only in this way does one gain access to the royal secrets which

pass in review all the animals in the world; in propitious darkness let him take time, like God, to prepare the material of the stars.

The most exquisite songs in nature are heard at night. The nightingale, the crystal-voiced toad, the cricket, sing in the darkness. The cock proclaims the day, and does not wait for it. All who bear a message, all poets, all seekers also and those who are on the alert to pick up the truths that lie scattered round us, must plunge deep into the vast emptiness which is plenitude.

No great man has tried to escape this law. Lacordaire said that he had made for himself in his room between his soul and God "a horizon wider than the world"; and had procured for him-

muse, under the delight-giving and tranquilizing caress of truth.

"Why hast thou come?" St. Bernard asked himself about the cloister: *ad quid venisti?* And you, thinker, why have you come to this life outside the ordinary life, to this life of consecration, concentration, and therefore of solitude? Was it not because of a choice? Did you not prefer truth to the daily lie of a scattered life, or even to the noble but secondary preoccupations of action? That being so, will you be unfaithful to the object of your devotion by falling back into the grip of what you have freely given up?

If the Spirit is to lead us into the regions of interior solitude, as He led Jesus into the desert, we

to be the prophet of the God within you who speaks a unique language to each man.

We shall come back later, at length, to this idea of an equipment special to each person, of a mental training which is education, that is, the drawing-out and unfolding of a soul: a soul that is unique, that has not had nor will have its like in all the ages, for God does not repeat Himself. But we must bear in mind that one can only unfold oneself in that fashion by first living with oneself, closely, in solitude.

The author of the *Imitation* said: "I have never gone amongst men without coming back less a man." Carry that idea further and say: without coming back less the man that I am, less myself.

strong, silence is their prayer." What a prayer indeed there is to truth, and what a power of co-operation with its influence in prolonged recollection—frequently resumed at specified times, as it were for a meeting which will gradually become a continuous contact, a life in close community! One cannot, says St. Thomas, contemplate all the time; but he who lives only for contemplation, directs everything else towards it, and resumes it when he can, gives it a sort of continuity, as far as may be on earth.[1]

Delight will be found in it, for "the cell, if you stay in it, grows sweet: *cella continuata dulcescit.*" Now the delight of contemplation is a part of its

[1] S.T. 1a 2ae, qu. 3, art. 2 ad 4m.

side. Before giving out truth, acquire it for yourself; and do not waste the seed for your sowing.

If the words of the *Imitation* are true, you will be more a man and more with men when you are far from them. In order to know humanity and to serve it, we must enter into ourselves, where all the objects we pursue are together in contact, and get from us either our strength of truth or our power of love.

One can only achieve union with anything through interior liberty. To allow oneself to be possessed, to be pulled hither and thither, whether by people or by things, is to promote disunion. Out of sight, near the heart.

united to God—without being a lover of silence and solitude—is but the subject of a kingdom of death.

III

All our explanations so far show clearly that the solitude we have extolled is a value needing to be modified by related values, which complete it and turn it to account. We are not pleading for a solitude without a purpose. The sacrifice of intercourse with our brethren and of their sympathy carries a compensation. The retirement to which we have a right must be a splendid isolation. Now, will it not be all the richer, all the more fruitful if

pupil and master of the others; if by some happy concourse of circumstances they could even live together! If besides lectures in the afternoon and study following on the lectures, they could talk in the evening, at supper, of all these noble things, so as to learn more by drinking them in in conversation, than by the very lectures!" [1]

The workshops of old, especially those of the artists, were a gathering of friends, a family. The workshop of today is a jail, or a union meeting. But in response to the need which makes itself more and more felt around us, shall we not see the old comradely workshop revived, widened, opened up, and yet no less closely united than of yore? The

[1] *Les Sources,* Première partie, Ch. VII.

that might spring from the impetus of a multitude or from stern necessity! One begins with enthusiasm, then as some difficulty arises, the demon of laziness whispers: What is the good? Our vision of the goal grows dim; the fruit of effort is too distant or appears too bitter; we have a vague sense of being duped. It is certain that the support of others, their example, the exchange of ideas, would be admirably efficacious against this gloomy mood; they would supply the place in many people of that power of imagination and constancy of virtue which only the few possess, yet which are necessary for the persevering prosecution of a great purpose.

In monasteries where there is no talking, no visiting, the influence of a corridor in which each little

new ideas, keeps up our ardor, and inflames our enthusiasm.

We have examples of all that in our day in young groups and young Reviews, in which men of understanding and conviction assume a task and devote themselves to an idea. The *Cahiers de la Quinzaine* [1] sprang from such a desire; the *Amitié de France,* the *Revue des Jeunes,* the *Revues de Juvisy* and *du Saulchoir* are every day more and more inspired by it. In these groups the workers do not always live together, but they work with the same spirit; they concert their efforts, they criticize

[1] The remarkable periodical, 1900-1914, of Charles Péguy, one of the men who has had the finest spiritual influence on modern French thought. (Tr. Note.)

that each one in his place should concentrate on the work while others also are concentrating: so that one task be accomplished, that one principle of life and activity be its guiding spirit; and that the parts of the watch, to each of which a home worker devotes his exclusive attention, be put together by God.

IV

I have also said that the solitude of the thinker does not imply neglect of his duties or forgetfulness of his needs. Certain contacts are necessary. Being necessary, they are part of our life: even of the life of an intellectual, since we do not separate the intellectual from the man. It is your task to link them with your intellectual life so that not

the different demands it makes will find their own balance. The good is the brother of the true: it will help its brother. To be where we ought to be, to do what we ought to do, disposes us for contemplation, and feeds it; it is leaving God for God, according to the saying of St. Bernard.

It is painful to have to sacrifice precious hours in visits and on business which are themselves beneath our ideal; but since after all the course of the world is made to be compatible with virtue, we must conclude that virtue, intellectual or moral, will find its profit in these things. On certain days it is only indirectly, by way of moral progress, that our intelligence will gain, in spite of its concessions to duty; in other circumstances it will gain of itself, directly.

realities like a sailor who has just come off his ship; he has lost the sense of the human lot; he seems to look on you as if you were a "proposition" to be inserted in a syllogism, or an example to be put down in a notebook.

In the inexhaustible wealth of the real, too, we can find much to learn; we must move in it in a spirit of contemplation, not keep away from it. And in the real is not man the most important thing for us—man, the center of all things, the goal to which all things lead, the mirror of all things, inviting the thinker of every specialty to permanent comparisons?

In the measure in which we can choose, we must arrange to consort as far as possible with superior

exacts from us.

Society is a book to read, even though a commonplace book. Solitude is a masterpiece; but remember the saying of Leibnitz, who found no book so bad that he could not get something out of it. You do not think alone, just as you do not think with your intelligence alone. Your intelligence takes your other faculties into partnership; your soul uses your body; your personality, its outside contacts; all these things together make up your thinking being. Adjust its component parts to the best of your power; but turn even its weak points, such as illness, into things of value by means of some happily ingenious greatness of soul.

However, in your association with others, bear

self while giving something to others, instead of letting your own torch go out as it lights other torches.

Besides, that is the way to give weight to one's words. Speech is weighty when one perceives silence beneath it, when it conceals and yet suggests a treasure behind the words, a treasure that it gives out little by little, as is fitting, without haste and frivolous excitement. Silence is the hidden content of the words that count. What makes the worth of a soul is the abundance of what it does not express.

V

What we have said of social contacts applies also with but little modification to action. The point is

we saw it might into the society of our fellows; and the same principles will apply. Action regulated by conscience prepares conscience itself for the rules of truth, disposes it for recollection when the time comes, unites it to Providence, which is also a source of truth. Thought and action have the same Father.

Then, even without obligation, it is always necessary for the thinker to reserve a part of his time and of his heart for the active life. It is sometimes a small part; but in a wise man it is never totally absent. The monk works with his hands or undertakes some apostolate; the great doctor has his hospitals; the artist his exhibitions, his group, his journeys, his lectures; the writer has so many calls on him

tinct from the body would not grow tired. But the living composite grows tired of rest as well as of exertion; it demands a balance, of which the center of gravity may move and vary from one man to another. A body too long motionless gets atrophied and nerveless; a soul which does the same wilts and broods. By carrying the cult of silence too far, one would reach the silence of death.

There is another point of view: intellectual life needs to feed on facts. One finds facts in books; but everyone knows that purely bookish knowledge is fragile; it suffers from the defect of the abstract; it loses contact and therefore sets before the judgment matter that is too fine-spun, almost illusory. "You are a captive balloon," said Amiel to himself: "see

leans on his crutches.

The element of action we are recommending to the thinker will have the advantage of steadying his mind. It will have the further advantage of enriching it. How many experiences life offers us every day! We let them pass, but a deep thinker gathers them up and makes his treasure of them; they will gradually fill out the framework of his thought, and his general ideas will be first tested and then illustrated by living examples.

The idea in us, devoid of its elements of experience, of its phantasms,[2] is but an empty concept,

[1] Ia, qu. 84, art. 8.

[2] *Phantasm*, in scholastic language, is the image of a thing left in the imagination. (Tr. Note.)

through action into the real, we find new forms in the matter of our observation, as the artist at work enriches, corrects, and completes his conception.

Lastly, action not only provides us with experience, but is also a teacher of energy whose lessons have their use for a solitary. By its solicitations and its resistances, by its difficulties, reverses, successes, by the boredom and weariness it forces us to overcome, by the contradictions it unfailingly arouses; and by the fresh needs it gives rise to, it stimulates us and retempers our powers; it shakes us out of our fundamental laziness and that self-satisfied quietude which are no less inimical to thought than to practical results.

can not find real rest or instruction or training in it. Therefore, if there are not already any demands on you, look for causes that will inspire you because they are worthwhile—movements that make for light, rehabilitation, preservation, progress; leagues for the public good, societies for defense of right and for social action, all such enterprises as demand of their man, if not his whole life, at least his whole self. Devote yourself to some such work in the moments when inspiration grants you, and even imposes on you, a leave of absence that will be to her

[1] Pascal's expression for those elements of conviction that depend on the experience of life and reality, and not on mere abstract reasoning—things known largely by instinct and intuition. (Tr. Note.)

whole of life. That is what matters most of all. It is said sometimes that solitude is the mother of results. Not solitude, but the state of solitude. So much so that we could, strictly speaking, conceive an intellectual life based on two hours' work per day. But does anyone imagine that having set those two hours aside one may then act as if they did not exist? That would be a grave misconception. Those two hours are given to concentration, but the consecration of the whole life is none the less necessary.

An intellectual must be an intellectual all the time. What St. Paul suggests to the Christian: whether you eat or drink or whatsoever else you do, do all to the glory of God, must apply to the Christian in search of light. For him the true is the

go out and act through duty, or wisdom, or for the sake of that relaxation of which we shall later plead the necessity, may be a higher kind of solitude, which feeds and tones up the soul instead of depressing and weakening it.

What St. Augustine calls the "purity of solitude" may be maintained everywhere; what destroys its purity may soil even its abiding-place. "You can be in a town," wrote Plato, "like a shepherd in his hut on the top of a hill." Keep your inward inspiration, your reserve, the love of what you have devoted yourself to, have the God of truth with you, and you are alone in the midst of the universe.

Study has been called a prayer to truth. Now prayer, the Gospel tells us, must be uninterrupted: "We ought always to pray and not to faint" (Luke 18:1). I know that this text is capable of a modified interpretation; the sense would then be: do not spend a day, a week, any long period, without speaking to God. But our masters have taken good care not so to narrow down words of such great import; they have taken them literally, and have drawn a profound doctrine from them.

Prayer is the expression of desire; its value comes from our inward aspirations, from their tenor and their strength. Take away desire, the prayer ceases; alter it, the prayer changes; increase or diminish its intensity, the prayer soars upward or has no

he is actively engaged in thinking for a very few hours only. Carlyle said he did not believe that any man of letters devoted the fifth part of his time to literature. Since the greater part of his life is thus on a dead level or lower, the man of the heights has no choice but to come down and to accept it: what a gain for him if he need not yield entirely to these humbler necessities!

As prayer can last all the time, because it is desire and the desire is constant, why should not study last all the time, seeing that it also is desire and an invocation of the true?

The desire of knowledge defines our intelligence as a vital force. Instinctively we want to know, as we ask for bread. If the majority of men remain

must, regularly and not intermittently, set the conscious or unconscious activity of the brain in motion.

The greater part of our nervous activity goes to waste because it is not tapped. In truth it cannot be fully turned to account, for our power over it is relative, and in trying to force the yield, one would destroy the machine. But what is possible is aimed at by very few people. Habit has great weight in this matter; wisely ordered, it acts like a second nature; and it is here that our practical advice comes in.

"Try to store everything that you can," says St. Thomas to the man of study, "in the cupboard of the mind, like one who aims at filling a vessel."

These would still be necessary, but the light concentrated in them would gradually diffuse itself so as to touch almost the whole of life; a circuit would be established, bringing under the study lamp the results of disseminated thinking, and then returning to give that thinking a direction, a habitual bearing, and therefore fruitfulness.

See what happens when you want to furnish a house. Until now you never thought of furniture, so little indeed that going about the streets of Paris where every fourth shop is a collector's, you did not even see the things; the shapes did not make you stop; you did not know the tendencies of fashion, the chances of a find, the specialty of this or that district, the prices, etc. On the contrary, now that

less universally. Every fact may give rise to a great thought. In all contemplation, even that of a fly or of a passing cloud, there is a fit occasion for endless reflection. Every light striking on an object may lead up to the sun; every road opened is a corridor to God.

Now, we could tap all that wealth if we were on the alert. If we looked at everything with an inspired spirit, we should find lessons everywhere—prophecies or confirmations, premonitory signs or consequences of truth. But most often we are not "on the spot," or not paying attention. "Everyone looks at what I am looking at," said Lamennais at Saint-Malo, as he stood on the seashore in a storm, "but no one sees what I see."

sight of a family make you think of past generations; and let the least contact with your fellows throw light on the highest conception of man. If you cannot look thus, you will become, or be, a man of only commonplace mind. A thinker is like a filter, in which truths as they pass through leave their best substance behind.

Learn to listen; and listen, first, to anyone. If it is in the marketplace, as Malherbe asserted, that one learns one's language, it is also in the marketplace, that is, in everyday life, that we can learn the language of the mind. A multitude of truths arises out of the simplest conversations. The least word listened to with attention may be an oracle. A peasant at certain moments is much wiser than a philosopher.

ful to all, for we all need this profound experience. The thinker is truly a thinker only if he finds in the least external stimulus the occasion of a limitless interior urge. It is his character to keep all his life the curiosity of childhood, to retain its vivacity of impression, its tendency to see everything under an aspect of mystery, its happy faculty of everywhere finding wonderment full of consequences.

However, be very specially on the watch when you have the good fortune to talk with someone who knows and who thinks. How sad it is that superior men are of so little service to those about them! In practice, they are set down as simpletons; people see in them what they have in common with others, not their own rare qualities. There is a

were borne on an invisible wave. The word of a great man is sometimes, like that of God, creative.

But it is an understood thing that great men are not great until after their death. The majority of people do not recognize them. Sitting beside you is perhaps a man as great as Descartes, and you do not listen to him, you do not question him, you argue with him in a carping spirit, you cut him short with trivial remarks. And if he is not quite so great, but has a fine mind, why do you allow him to bury his wealth or to carry it away in silence?

By observing and listening—I do not mention reading because we shall come back to that—you will learn to reflect, you will assimilate and adapt to your own needs what you have acquired. Great

present study, to the work in hand. Carry your problems about with you. The hackney horse does his run and goes back to his stall; the free courser always has his nostrils to the wind.

Since truth is everywhere and all things are connected, why not study each question in contact with kindred questions? Everything should contribute to our specialty. Everything should bear witness for or against our theses. To a large extent the universe is what we make of it. The painter everywhere sees form, color, movement, expression; the architect balances masses; the musician perceives rhythm and sound; the poet finds subjects for metaphor; a thinker sees ideas in act.

We are not here advocating any narrow particu-

be present to us every moment. Is it wise, is it normal, to leave the man of research behind in the study, to have as it were two souls: the soul of the worker and the soul of the easygoing everyday man? This dualism is not natural; it gives ground for thinking that the pursuit of the true is a business with us, instead of being a noble passion.

All things have their season, says the Bible, and I agree that we cannot avoid making a division of time; but since as a matter of fact we are always thinking, why not utilize that thought to the advantage of what we have in mind?

Someone may say that such tension is incompatible with mental health and with the conditions of life. Granted; but then it is not a question of ten-

not? You have here an immense resource; you can use it by putting a little discipline into an operation that the brain is always performing, but without your intervention and without control. Regulate that operation, and let your brain also be an intellectual worker.

In practice, you will perceive that this is not in the least tiring, that on the contrary it saves a great deal of fatigue; for the unsought finds, made like that just by looking about, made simply because one has resolved and trained oneself not to be blind, those discoveries that are often happiest because spontaneous, greatly encourage the seeker; they keep him alert and joyous; he waits with de-

whole process takes place without us—I mean without any deliberate act of will, merely under the impression of the desire which is the soul of the thinker and which characterizes him, as play does childhood, and love, woman—it does not involve the strain that people imagine.

Does a woman out walking get tired of watching for the admiration of the passers-by; a girl of being ready for a laugh, or a little boy of frolicking? The mind on the look-out for truth through love, not through compulsion—through a tendency instinctive at first, then cultivated but cultivated lovingly, passionately—will not toil any more than these. Such a mind is at play; like a fowler with his gun, it is enjoying a useful and delightful sport; it loves

truth given out in its mighty activities.

II

Père Gratry insistently recommends us not to exclude from continuous work the hours of lethargy and darkness. He wants night to be made to work. This advice rests on psychology and on experience.

Sleep is a relaxing of tension; the conscious will lays down its function, ceases to trouble about living, aims at no purpose, and thus finds itself largely given over to the general condition of nature. The attitude of the sleeper is no empty symbol; he lies nearer to earth, as if he said to nature: Take me back; long enough have I held out against your powers; standing, I have combated your determin-

It is not a question of keeping awake; on the contrary, the night-walker is a bad worker; on this point we have said that we must obey the demands of general hygiene, which should be even more insistent in the case of a man of study. But sleep itself is a worker, a partner of the daily toil; we can make its forces serve us, utilize its laws, profit by that filtering process, that clarification which takes place during the self-surrender of the night.

A bit of brain-work begun, an idea just started, an idea that some interior or exterior happening had prevented from fully shaping itself or finding its natural place, is developed during the night and links up with others; do not miss this opportunity

Nature is not at our command; she goes her way; her river brings gold in its current, but we ourselves have to recover, not to allow to be engulfed, the precious deposit washed along to us in the treasure-bearing waves.

Very often, gleams of light come in a few minutes' sleeplessness, in a second perhaps; you must fix them. To entrust them to the relaxed brain is like writing on water; there is every chance that on the morrow there will be no slightest trace left of any happening.

Do better than that. Have at hand a notebook or a box of slips. Make a note without waking up too fully, without turning on the light, if possible, then

Every thinker has experienced instances of early morning lucidity that are sometimes surprising, almost miraculous. Complete treatises have thus grown fully clear, after a long and laborious series of complicated studies during which the author felt as if he were lost in a wood with no open space or vista ahead anywhere.

Inventions have come about like that. Elements scattered in the mind, old experiments or bits of information of no apparent interest have converged, and problems have been solved of themselves by a spontaneous classification of the mental images which stood for the idea of their solution.

Quick to your notebook when such a piece of good fortune befalls you. Follow up the idea as

ticle must be lost. It is so much labor saved for the day. Night, collaborating loyally, has given you without your stir, a complete day of twenty-four hours—perhaps even weeks—the time that it would have taken to hammer out by deliberate effort the splendid jewel now presented to you.

However, it is not enough to take care to gather the fruit. Sleep works of itself, but it works on existing material; it creates nothing; it is skilled in combining and simplifying, in bringing things to a head, but it can only work on the findings of experience and the labor of the day. Its work must be prepared for it. To count on it means to count first of all on oneself.

Monks have the custom, as old as the devout life,

for me; determinism is the slave of free will and will turn its millstone while I rest; I can suspend my effort; the heavens are revolving, and as they turn they set moving in my brain delicate machinery that I might put out of order; I sleep; nature keeps watch; God keeps watch, and tomorrow I shall gather a little of the fruit of their work.

In this quiet spirit, you relax completely, more than if you thought anxiously of a morrow without help, more above all than by living over again at night, as so often happens, the worries of the day—worries exaggerated by semi-unconsciousness, which poison the night and will be there again in the morning to serve you up their bitter draught.

Just as gentle and regular work can give harmony

III

Hence the extreme importance, for the worker as well as for the religious man, of the mornings and evenings. One cannot prepare, supervise and end the hours of rest with an attentive spirit if those that immediately precede and follow are left to chance.

The morning is sacred; in the morning our soul, refreshed, looks out on life as from a turning-point from which we see it in one view. Our destiny lies outspread before us. We resume our task; this is the moment to accept it afresh, and to confirm, by an express act, our triple vocation as men, Christians, and intellectuals.

tion, and, above all, of the Mass, if one has the possibility of hearing it or the happiness of saying it.

Waking must be a *Sursum corda!* To repeat a form of prayer at that moment is an excellent practice; to say it aloud is better; for, as psychologists know, our voice has an effect of self-suggestion on us and plays towards us the part of a double. That is a "slave" that we may not neglect; he has authority from us, he is *us,* and his voice reaches us with the strange domination of one who is at once the same and different.

Children are taught "to give their heart to God"; the intellectual, a child in that respect, must in addition give his heart to truth; he must remember

especially appropriate to himself, should extract its fruit and form from it the good resolution that will be kept by Christian work.

An act of faith in the lofty truths that are the foundation of knowledge; an act of hope that God will help us to light as well as to virtue; an act of love for Him who is infinitely lovable and for those whom our study aims at bringing near to Him; the *Pater* to ask for our bread and for the food of our intelligence; an *Ave* addressed to the Woman clothed with the sun, victorious over error as over evil. In these forms of words and in others, the intellectual finds his needs expressed, reminds himself of his task; and he can, without isolating his

poverty succored by His riches which it is your task to succor along with Him, which you must enlighten and do your part to save while saving yourself?

The Mass really puts you into a state of eternity, into the spirit of the universal Church, and in the *Ite missa est* you are ready to see a mission, a sending out of your zeal to the destitution of the mad and ignorant earth.

The morning hours thus bedewed with prayer, freshened and vivified by the breezes of the spirit, cannot fail to be fruitful; you will begin them with faith; you will go through them with courage; the whole day will be spent in the radiance of the early

to bed with minds relaxed.

Yes, indeed, relaxed; but like a violin with all its strings completely slackened. What a labor next day to tune them all up again!

I know industrialists who find their relaxation in reading Pascal, Montaigne, Ronsard, Racine. Deep in a comfortable armchair well lit from behind, beside the fire, their family around them, quiet, or in the buzz of pleasant activity, they *live* awhile after having toiled all day. This is their moment; this is the moment of the man, when the specialist has done facing up with head and heart to innumerable difficulties.

An intellectual, if he does not need this mental compensation, needs the quietness even more. His

must be set aside for the life of pleasure, dissipation is not rest, it is exhaustion. Rest cannot be found in scattering one's energies. Rest means giving up all effort and withdrawing towards the fount of life; it means restoring our strength, not expending it foolishly.

I know indeed that to expend is sometimes to acquire: that is true of sport, of recreation, and we shall not merely tolerate, we shall demand, such active relaxation. But that is not the normal function of the evening. For the evening there is a double rest, spiritual and physical; rest in God and rest in mother nature. Now the first comes from prayer; the other, the rest of the body, precedes

worthy eve of the festival that every new day should be for the Christian.

The sleeper often unconsciously takes up the position that he had long ago in his mother's womb. That is a symbol. Rest is a return to our origins: the origins of life, of strength, of inspiration; it is a retempering; that is signified by our withdrawal in the evening from the world and into ourselves. Now retempering cannot possibly be attained through fussy activity; it is rather like seeking a refuge, renewing the vigor of the human spirit by peaceful concentration; it is a restoration of organic life and of holy life in us by easing off happily, by prayer, silence, and sleep.

ment of these values obeys different laws, we cannot lay down any absolute rule; but we must insist on this one thing: you must study yourself, consider what your life is, what it enables you to do, what it furthers or excludes, what of itself it suggests for the hours of intense activity.

Will these be in the morning or in the evening, or partly in the morning and partly in the evening? You alone can decide, because you alone know your obligations and your character on which the mapping-out of your days depends.

When you have only a few free hours and can place them at will, morning seems to deserve the preference. Night has renewed your strength; prayer has given you wings; peace reigns all about

for trifles.

Further, in order to keep this time for your work and to keep it really free, rise punctually and promptly; breakfast lightly; avoid futile conversations, useless calls, limit your correspondence to what is strictly necessary; gag the newspapers! These rules, which we have given as a general safeguard for the life of study, apply most of all to its intense hours.

If you have so foreseen and settled everything, you can get straight at your work; you will be able to plunge deep into it, to get absorbed and to make progress; your attention will not be distracted, your effort scattered. Avoid half-work more than anything. Do not imitate those people who sit

your whole being conscious of the silent stars above you, even by day, when they still shine faithfully. Beneath your feet, far below, will the sounds of life be; you will not notice them, you will hear only the music of the spheres which symbolizes in Scipio's Dream the harmony of the forces of creation.

Thus to open up one's being to truth, to withdraw from all else, and, if I may say so, to take a ticket for a different world, is true work. That is the kind of work of which we speak when we say that two hours daily are enough to yield a tangible worthwhile result. Evidently, they are not much; but they really suffice if all the conditions are fulfilled; and they are better than the fifteen hours a

Gold-beater, battage; the resemblance of the words is suggestive.[1] Many people are the dupe of appearances, of vague and muddle-headed intentions, talk all the time and never work.

We must remark that the period of intensive work cannot be any more uniform than our intellectual life as a whole. Proportionally, it has the same phases; one gets into swing gradually, sometimes with great difficulty, one reaches one's maximum, and then grows tired. There is a complete cycle: fresh morning, burning midday, evening de-

[1] *Battage*, a colloquial word for log-rolling, self-advertisement. The idea might be suggested in English by pairing the words gold-*beater*, drum-*beating*. (Tr. Note.)

Keep a Cerberus at your door. Every demand on you from outside is a loss of inner power and may cost your mind some precious discovery: "when half-gods go, the gods arrive." [1]

But note that this complete solitude, the only favorable atmosphere for work, need not be understood physically. Someone else's presence may double, instead of disturbing, your quietude. To have near you another worker equally ardent, a friend absorbed in some kindred thought or occupation, a chosen spirit who understands your work, joins in it, seconds your effort by silent affection and a keenness fired by your own—that is not a distraction, it is a help.

[1] Ralph Waldo Emerson. *Poems.*

secure they are against the outside world.

Yet the fact remains that solitude, once understood and arranged for, must be obstinately defended. You must listen to no one, neither indiscreet friends, nor ununderstanding relatives, nor chance comers, nor charity itself. You cannot be charitable in every direction at once. You belong to truth; serve her first. Except in certain clear and obvious cases, nothing should take precedence of your vocation.

The time of a thinker, when he really uses it, is in reality charity to all; only thus do we appreciate it properly. The man of truth belongs to the human race with truth itself; there is no risk of selfishness when one has isolated oneself jealously

of these things in his *Sixteen Precepts*. In reality, this is a matter of personal vocation, closely dependent on the object in view. However, certain indications are possible, and they may afford a starting-point for profitable reflections.

We are not taking this question at its first beginnings; we are addressing people who have left schooldays behind and now propose to plan out or to complete deeper studies. At this level, the subject gives rise to P. Gratry's interesting observations on *Comparative Study*. It may appear that the development of this theme in *Les Sources* is somewhat out of date; but the substance remains and would deserve to be seriously considered by young intellectuals.

nothing; but also for one whose mind is shrunken and shrivelled because he has prematurely confined himself to the cultivation of one department of study.

We may assert without any paradox that every branch of science pursued home would lead to the other sciences, science to poetry, poetry and science to ethics, and then to politics and even to religion on its human side.

Everything is in everything, and partitions are only possible by abstraction. To abstract is not to lie, says the proverb: *abstrahere non est mentiri;* but that is on condition that the process of abstraction which distinguishes, methodically isolates, concentrates its light on a point, does not separate

the beginning. Lay your foundations according to the height that you aim to reach; broaden the opening of the excavation according to the depth it has to reach. But still you must understand that knowledge is neither a tower nor a well, but a human habitation. A specialist, if he is not a man, is a mere quill-driver; his egregious ignorance makes him like a lost wanderer among men; he is unadapted, abnormal, a fool. The intellectual Catholic will not copy such a model. Destined to serve the human race by his vocation, he wants first to belong to it as a man; he must walk boldly on the ground in stable equilibrium, not skipping on tiptoe.

In the pursuit of knowledge we have tried in

admits of, still less real life. Physics, chemistry, obsess you by their complexity and give no breadth to the mind. Physiology leads to materialism; astronomy to vague speculation; geology turns you into a nosing hound; literature makes you hollow; philosophy inflates you; theology hands you over to false sublimity and magisterial pride. You must pass from one spirit to the other so as to correct one by the other; you must cross your crops in order not to ruin the soil.

And do not imagine that to carry this comparative study *to a certain point* is to overload yourself and to lose time about embarking on a special study. You will not overload yourself, for the lights thrown by one subject on another will, on the con-

helps each of them, for at bottom they are one.

Moreover, the vigorous instinct and the enthusiasm aroused in every man of good ability who moves about thus in the realms of knowledge, who explores those splendid territories as he might visit turn by turn the fiords of Norway, the Golden Horn, the burial chambers of Egypt, the prairies of America, and the palaces of China—that species of epic ardor which fires a strong intelligence in contact with the wonders of the mind, gives a marvelous zest and facility to study.

A rabbi, reproached with adding to the burdens of the law, answered: When a bushel is full of nuts, one can still pour into it many measures of oil. That man had zeal, which in regard of spiritual

oneself at the center of knowledge, where the sciences cease to exist separately.

You do not aspire to anything like that? No: but proportionately to each one of us what the great have done remains an indication of what may be achieved. Make yourself a broad plan, which will gradually be narrowed down as regards the time devoted to each secondary study, but never as regards breadth of view and the spirit of your work.

Choose your advisers well. One among a thousand for the whole of your work, others for each part of it if necessary. Divide your time, regulate the order of your subjects: these things cannot be done at haphazard.

In everything go straight to what is essential; do

philosophy, discrown themselves and lose their direction. The sciences and philosophy without theology discrown themselves more lamentably, since the crown they repudiate is a heavenly one;

[1] It is remarkable that at the present time, the scientist is called on by his very science to elucidate problems that hitherto were of the exclusive domain of philosophy; causality, determinism, probability, continuity and discontinuity, space, time, etc. Logically, the scientist should borrow his notions from the philosopher; but most often the philosopher, satisfied with his age-old categories, declines the task of enlightening the scientist; and the scientist has to philosophize for himself, which he does without experience and often wrongly.

[2] See especially in the *Summa,* the whole of the *First Question;* in the Commentary on the *De Trinitate* of Boethius *Question II,* art. 2; in the *Contra Gentes,* Chapter I of the First Book.

upwards; and it is not surprising that it sheds light on it.

If the intellectual Catholic belongs to his time, he can do nothing better than work, for his part, at restoring the order that we lack. What, from the point of view of doctrine, is wanting in the knowledge of our time, is not positive content, it is harmony, a harmony that can come only from an appeal to first principles.[1]

The order of the mind must correspond to the order of things; and since the mind does not really

1 Charles Dunan wrote this striking sentence: "For modern philosophy, transcendental problems are non-existent. But the converse is true: if these problems exist, it is modern philosophy that is non-existent." *Les Deux Idéalismes,* page 182, Paris, Alcan, 1911.

shining tinsel ornaments and no garments, splendid chapters and no finished book, no Bible.

The Summae of old were the Bibles of knowledge: we have now no Summae, and no one among us is capable of writing one. Everything is in chaos. But at least, if a collective Summa is premature, every man who thinks and really desires to *know* can try to establish his personal Summa, that is to introduce order into his knowledge by an appeal to the principles of order; in a word, by philosophizing, and by crowning his philosophy with a concise but profound theology.

Christian scholars and scientists from the beginning of our era until the end of the seventeenth century, were all theologians; and men of learning

of the findings of human effort to the collaboration of heaven, all branches of knowledge are vivified and all disciplines broadened. The unity of faith gives to intellectual work the stamp of a vast co-operation. It is the collective operation of men united in God. And that is why Christian knowledge, as it now is, and still more as it will be when the Summa of modern times is written, cannot but exceed in fulness and in inspiration all the great works achieved by antiquity and by neo-paganism. The Encyclopedias[1] no more come near it than Babel does to our cathedrals.

It ought to be impossible for one who seeks truth

[1] An allusion to the *Encyclopédie*, the great monument of French free thought in the eighteenth century. (Tr. Note.)

mind, that will be quite enough; afterwards you will only have to keep up what you know.

But beware above everything else of trusting false teachers. Go straight to St. Thomas of Aquin. Study the *Summa,* having first made sure to inform yourself exactly of the content of the faith. Have at hand the *Catechism of the Council of Trent,* which is in itself a masterly epitome of theology.[1] Get a good grip of that manual and continue day by day with St. Thomas the rational development of the divine science. The text will at first appear

[1] As a help, I venture to indicate the *Catéchisme des Incroyants,* published (by Flammarion) in order to make it easier for our contemporaries to understand Christian doctrine and its foundations.

Some introductory book giving a preliminary idea and a first taste of the content of St. Thomas would be useful. Do not linger over it; but take the hand offered to give you a start.[2]

[1] Some people, on reading this sentence, imagined that the author possessed a secret for teaching Latin in two months! He was not speaking of Latin, but of St. Thomas' language, which is to classical Latin pretty much what the Montagne Ste-Geneviève is to the Pic du Midi (the Montagne Ste-Geneviève is the rising ground on the south bank of the Seine, the old Paris University District [Tr. Note]). The Thomistic vocabulary is so limited, the turns of speech so often recur and are so free from the features that make Latin difficult, that really only laziness can hesitate when a treasure is to be had at the price of so slight an effort.

[2] Cf. as an elementary work: Jacques Maritain, *Eléments de Philosophie,* Téqui 1920. For the more advanced student,

refer you; consult the *Index Tertius,* an imperfect treasure, but a treasure all the same; compare text with text; make the different sources of information complete and illustrate one another, and draw up your own article. It is an excellent gymnastic, which will give your mind flexibility, vigor, precision, breadth, hatred of sophistry and of inexactitude, and at the same time insure you a progressively increasing store of notions that will be clear, deep, consecutive, always linked up with their first principles and forming by their interadaptation a sound synthesis.

A. D. Sertillanges, *Saint Thomas d'Aquin,* in the Collection des Grands Philosophes, Alcan 1910.

in this respect Thomism is sovereign.

Here I expect protests. I had them in 1920,[1] I must foresee fresh ones. And so I think it well to say to anyone who is willing to put some trust in me: the longer I go on, the more convinced I am that the future of our intelligent Catholics really lies here—for their own intrinsic worth, and what is more and *more than anything,* for their adaptation to the present time. The partisans of the latest novelty may say what they like, the weight of a doctrine and its newness are two different things. Genius has no date. When eternal things are in question, it is wisdom to turn to the man who, at

[1] A reference to the earlier edition. (Tr. Note.)

olics who read me: study St. Thomas, he is the man of our day. You would think he had been created seven centuries ago to quench our thirst. Compared to the muddy water now served up to us, he is a clear spring. When by a vigorous effort you have overcome the first difficulties of an archaic mode of exposition, he reassures your mind, floods it with light, and provides a setting both strong and flexible for its further acquisitions.

Thomism is a synthesis. That does not mean that it is a complete system of knowledge; but a complete system of knowledge can find in it an almost miraculous power to coordinate and uplift. If a pope could say of St. Thomas' work in detail *Quot*

thought and experience.

Other systems are opposed to adjacent systems: Thomism reconciles them in a higher light, taking account of what led them into error and careful to be just to all that is right in them. Other systems have been contradicted by facts: Thomism goes to meet facts, envelopes them, interprets them, classifies them, and establishes them as it were by legal right.

No metaphysic offers natural science more helpful principles of order and of higher interpretation; no rational psychology is in closer correspondence with all the discoveries of experimental psychology and its dependent sciences; no cosmology is more adaptable or readier to welcome the dis-

judges that its structure as a whole corresponds to the constitution of reality and of the intelligence, and she notes that both knowledge and faith converge on it, because it has taken up its position between them like a fortress at a meeting of the roads.

In such a domain one cannot lay down rules; but I say to the man who undertakes comparative study, that is, who resolves to carry on together as one single research special branches of study along with philosophy and theology: consult your powers; try to find in your heart enough faith in your age-old guide not to hesitate to give her willing and filial loyalty. If you can do that, your fidelity will have its reward; you will rise to a level unknown to

extent in itself is nothing, and that penetration, introducing us to the central point of observed facts, gives us the substance of what an interminable pursuit sought to discover.

We have pleaded for a certain extension, but it was for the sake of depth and as a means of mental formation; when this formation is attained and the possibilities of profound work are assured, we must begin to dig deep, and only specialization enables us to do this.

It oftens happens that what is indispensable at first becomes injurious later on. The harm would show itself here in many ways and would lead by different roads to mental deterioration.

effort; their progress, rapid at first, is like that of the will o' the wisp on the ground. No energy continues to exert itself for long unless it is stimulated by increasing difficulty, and sustained by the increasing interest of some laborious investigation. When the whole field of study has been surveyed and its connections and unity estimated in the light of fundamental principles, it is urgently necessary, if one does not want merely to mark time, to turn to some task which is precise, defined in its limits, proportioned to one's strength; and then to throw oneself into it with all one's heart.

What we suggested a while ago has its converse here. We said that you must follow various paths

person; trying to be a giant, one lessens one's stature as a man.

Everyone in life has his work; he must apply himself to it courageously and leave to others what Providence has reserved for others. We must keep from specialization as long as our aim is to become cultivated men, and, as far as concerns those to whom these pages are addressed, superior men; but we must specialize anew when we aim at being men with a function, and producing something useful. In other words, we must *understand* everything, but in order to succeed in *doing* some one thing.

virtue and gives us a great dignity, that of the man who lives according to his law and plays his part. We are not much, but we are part of a whole and we have the honor of being a part. What we do not do, we do all the same; God does it, our brethren do it, and we are with them in the unity of love.

Therefore, do not imagine you can do everything. Measure yourself, measure your task; after some experiments, make up your mind, though without rigidity, to accept your limits; preserve, by reading and if necessary by a certain amount of writing, the advantage of your early studies, your contact with wide fields of knowledge—but for the main part of your time and strength, concentrate.

mode of its application, a spirit of earnestness. "Clear up your doubts" said St. Thomas to his disciple.

An active mind is constantly in search of some truth which for it, at the moment, is the representation of that integral truth to which it has vowed its service. The intelligence is like a child, whose lips never cease their *why*. Does a good educator leave this fruitful restless questioning unsatisfied? Does he not take advantage of this fresh curiosity, as of a youthful appetite, to give solid food to the nascent spiritual organism? Our soul does not age; it is always growing; in regard of truth it is always a child; we who have charge of its permanent education must not, as far as possible, leave any of the

haps, given our make-up; but we must either be prepared for it or relinquish the idea of study: for what can be done without virile energy? "O God, Thou sellest all good things to men at the price of effort," wrote Leonardo da Vinci in his notes. He himself remembered it.

The mind is like the airplane which can only keep aloft by going forward with all the power of its propeller. To stop is to crash. On the other hand, earnestness and tenacity can carry us beyond all foreseen limits into regions undreamed of. People do not know how plastic the intelligence is and how capable of being trained to higher flights. Bossuet said: "The mind of man can make infinite discoveries, sloth alone puts limits to its wisdom

merely aim at display, or some advantage, a small stock of ideas may suffice. Many people get along like that with a sort of handy screen, concealing their vast ignorance from others and from themselves. But a real vocation is not so cheaply satisfied; it looks on every gain as a new starting-point. To know, to seek, to know more and to start afresh to seek more, is the life of a man devoted to truth, just as to make more money, whatever his fortune, is the aim of the miser. The intellectual who is sincere says every day to the God of truth: "The zeal of Thy house hath eaten me up."

As one grows older, one needs more than ever to be on one's guard against this temptation. We know the sort of people called "bonzes," learned

A real thinker brings a very different spirit to his work; he is carried along by the instinct of a conqueror, by an urge, an enthusiasm, an inspiration, that are heroic. A hero does not stand still or set himself limits. A Guynemer looks on one victory as a rehearsal for another; with unfailing vigor he makes flight after flight, closes with an adversary, turns round on another, and only in death sees the end of his career.

We must always seek, always endeavor. Nature makes the wilderness flower anew, the star to shine, the water to flow down slopes, round obstacles, into empty places, dreaming of the sea that waits it yonder, and which it may at last reach. Creation in every one of its stages is continuous

radiated freely takes fire at the focal point where the heat is intensified.

Let your mind become a lens, thanks to the converging rays of attention; let your soul be all intent on whatever it is that is established in your mind as a dominant, wholly absorbing idea. Make an orderly series of your different studies, so as to throw yourself into them completely. Let each task take entire hold of you, as if it were the only one. That was Napoleon's secret; it is the secret of all who are great in action. Men of genius themselves were great only by bringing all their powers to bear on the point on which they had decided to concentrate.

We must allow each thing its separate place, do

set up a system of watertight compartments, work intensively at the point we are engaged on and not change to another until afterwards.

Doing a bit here and a bit there is never any good. The traveller who hesitates and tries different roads one after another, loses courage and makes no headway. On the contrary, to pursue one path steadily, to start off continually with fresh energy and then rest at the right moment—that is, when the first phase of activity is complete—is the way to produce our utmost, and at the same time to keep our mind fresh, our courage intact. The soul of a true worker, in spite of his preoccupations and the number of them that may press one on the other, should always, between two earnest

All the productions of a well-endowed and well-formed mind should be nothing else than developments of a single thought, of a feeling for life seeking its forms and its applications. Did not M. Bergson recently tell us that again? "A philosopher worthy of the name," he writes, "never said more than one single thing." *A fortiori,* all the work of a particular period in connection with one subject or one spell of study, must be strictly disciplined in one direction. To dig and dig into the same hole is the way to get down deep and to surprise the secrets of earth.

One of the effects of this concentration is to bring about a selection in the confused mass of material that almost always confronts us at the be-

III

But there is something else still more important, namely, to submit not only to the discipline of work, but to the discipline of truth. This submission to truth is the binding condition for communion with it. Prompt obedience is what invites it to visit us. To this sacred meeting we must bring a respectful soul. Truth will not give itself to us unless we are first rid of self and resolved that it shall suffice us. The intelligence which does not submit is in a state of skepticism, and the skeptic is ill-prepared for truth. Discovery is the result of sympathy; and sympathy is the gift of self.

By thought we *find* things, we do not make

Study might be defined by saying that it is God becoming conscious in us of His work. Like every action, intellection passes from God to God, as it were, through us. God is its first cause; He is its last end; on the way, our too assertive self can deflect the movement. Let us rather open our eyes wisely so that our inspiring Spirit may see *in us*.

Our intellect is, taking it all in all, a passive faculty; one is intellectually strong in proportion as one is receptive. Not that we have not to react to the stimulus; but the vital reaction about which we shall speak at length must not change the tenor of our acquisitions, it must only make them our own. Wide culture, filling the mind with ideas, starts it on new lines of thought and increases its

Activity which is too intentional makes our intelligence less sure and less receptive; if we strive too anxiously, we remain shut up in ourselves, whereas to understand is to become *other,* and in happy receptivity to let truth pour in upon us. Try to project your thought into the object of knowledge, not to keep it within yourself; as in speaking one must speak out into space, not into one's sinuses. Singers know what I mean; those who have experienced inspiration will understand me also. You must look through the mind in the direction of things, not into the mind, which is more or less forgetful of things. In the mind we have the means of seeing, not the object of sight: let the means not distract us from the goal.

truths, is the attitude of contemplation and of fruitful production. One is then in a sense like the animal in the forest, concentrated, watchful, crouching with his eye on his prey; and the inner life is intense, but with a sense of distance as if one were moving among the stars. One feels at once delivered from all trammels and yet enchained, free and enslaved; one is fully oneself in surrendering to what is above self; one exults while forgetting self: it is a nirvana in which the intelligence is intensely happy and active.

Do not then discourage this spirit if it visits you, driving it away in favor of some artificial and external form of work. If it is absent, hasten its re-

[1] See pp. ix, 31, 255.

memory everything good that is said."

The history of the sciences teems with examples of the resistance of talent to talent, genius to genius, coterie to coterie, clique to clique. Laënnec opposes Broussais, Pouchet opposes Pasteur; Lister has England against him, Harvey the whole of humanity above forty years of age. You would think that truth was too prolific and that its rapid multiplication had to be checked! And yet the laws of the world reign over matter: why has mind such difficulty in forcing the assent of mind?

In the First Epistle to the Corinthians, Chapter 14, we read that if to the least of the faithful is

[1] Ps. 83:11.

allegiance to anyone, so still less must we disdain anyone; and if it is not expedient to believe everybody neither must we refuse to believe anyone who can show his credentials.

That is our great liberty. This readiness to accept truth brings so rich a reward that it would tempt even avarice itself, if the avaricious thinker did not imagine it wiser to sit guarding his own coffers. We like to believe that we possess everything, that we are capable of everything, and we give but an inattentive hearing to the voice of others. We make a few favored exceptions, men or books; they have our ear and afford us inspiration.

[1] *In Evang. Joann.* C.IX. lect. 3, end.
[2] Msgr. Knox's translation.

passed, shall we not gather in the harvest?

IV

Lastly, in order to ennoble the spirit of our work, we must add to earnestness, concentration, submission, an effort at breadth which will give to each study or to each product of our thought a kind of universal bearing.

A problem cannot be self-contained; by its very nature it exceeds its own limits; for the intelligibility that it presupposes is borrowed from sources higher than itself. What we have said of comparative study guides us here. Every object of our investigation belongs to a whole in which it acts and is acted upon, in which it is subject to conditions

also is a unity; it cannot be satisfactorily formed on the false idea of specialties considered as a breaking-up of the true and the beautiful into scattered fragments. However restricted your investigation may be, however minute the subject that you are pursuing, the whole of man and the universe are really involved. The subject and the object both tend to the universal. Truly to study a thing means evoking step by step the sense of all other things and of their solidarity—mingling in the concert of all beings, entering into union with the universe and with oneself.

We spoke a moment ago of concentration; but it was clear that we did not thereby seek to narrow down our study. To concentrate and to look abroad

seer while plucking the little twigs of truth, and, what is still more obviously necessary, do not reduce sublime questions to petty proportions. Be conscious that you are touching on great secrets, sharing the inspiration of great souls; perceive the light that trickles in here or there, while farther off, in continuity with this slender gleam, it floods worlds as it flows unbrokenly from the pure Source of all things.

Corot does not paint a tree and forget the horizon; Velásquez poses his Meninas[1] in mid-Escurial, in mid-life, better still in mid-Being; for it is that feeling for the mystery of Being that turns

1 *Las Meninas*, the Maids of Honour, a picture by Velásquez in the Museo del Rey, Madrid. (Tr. Note.)

intellectual vocation to allow oneself to be tied down by narrow prescriptions and to have one's mind benumbed into bookish forms. Helots or eternal children: such are those pretended workers who are out of their element in any higher region, in face of any broad horizon, and who would like to reduce others to their narrow elementary school orthodoxy.

It is the mark of genius to see, in one's work, what will not go into it; in books what they cannot express. The real treasure of a great book is what is between the lines; it suggests; it makes one reflect that nothing is foreign to the deepest thoughts of man. Therefore, instead of narrowing down restricted subjects and emptying them of all con-

Anyone who takes the trouble to think will realize that the kind of dazzlement we feel at the vision of a new truth is linked with this sense of indefinite vistas and universal connections. This one single step in the direction of the true is like a sunlit excursion. One sees the world under a new light, one feels the whole universe vibrating in contact with the fragment discovered. Later on, this idea, reduced to its own dimensions after having played the part of a forerunner, may seem petty to him whom it dazzled; with no reverberation outside itself, it seems lifeless, it disappoints the feeling for the infinite which is the soul of all research.

Great men have suffered from this shrinkage of their thoughts. Their vision was great, they find

gates of the infinite are always open. The most precious part of anything is what is not expressed. Was it not Biot[1] who, addressed by a colleague in the words: "I am going to ask you an interesting question," replied: "It's no use: if your question is interesting, I do not know the answer." "We do not know all of anything" says Pascal; and Claude Bernard[2] adds: "To understand a single thing thoroughly, we should understand all things." One may say of the full truth in any subject whatever the same thing that St. Augustine said of God: "If you understand, say to yourself that your reasoning

[1] A French physicist and astronomer, 1774-1862. (Tr. Note.)
[2] A great French physiologist, 1813-1878. (Tr. Note.)

lights attract us as long as we have the hope of reaching them. On the contrary, if we think that everything has been said and that we have only to learn, we work in a little circle and stick fast in the same spot.

A noble character knows that our lights are only the degrees of shadow by which we climb toward the inaccessible light. We stammer, and the enigma of the world remains unsolved. Study means specifying a few conditions, classifying a few facts; great and fruitful study comes only from putting the little we achieve under the favoring direction of what we do not yet know. That does not mean consigning it to darkness; for it is the light we do

a long preparation is needed. For production is a result; and in order to learn, when the subject matter is difficult or complex, one must first have gone through what is simple and easy: "You must go to the sea by the streams, and not all at once," St. Thomas tells us.

Now reading is the universal means of learning, and it is the proximate or remote preparation for every kind of production.

We never think entirely alone: we think in company, in a vast collaboration; we work with the workers of the past and of the present. The whole intellectual world can be compared, thanks to reading, to a great editorial or mercantile office, where each one finds in those about him the initiation,

not be done without much reading. But *much* and *little* are opposites only in the same domain. Here much is necessary in the absolute sense, because the work to be done is vast; but little, relatively to the deluge of writing that, even in the most restricted special fields, floods our libraries and our minds nowadays.

What we are proscribing is the passion for reading, the uncontrolled habit, the poisoning of the mind by excess of mental food, the laziness in disguise which prefers easy familiarity with others' thought to personal effort.

The passion for reading which many pride them-

1 A notable literary critic, of rationalistic and positivist turn of mind. (Tr. Note.)

tion; it grows inwardly extroverted, if one can so express oneself, becomes the slave of its mental images, of the ebb and flow of ideas on which it has eagerly fastened its attention. This uncontrolled delight is an escape from self; it ousts the intelligence from its function and allows it merely to follow point for point the thoughts of others, to be carried along in the stream of words, developments, chapters, volumes.

The continual sight stimuli thus occasioned destroy mental energy, as constant vibration wears out steel. There is no real work to be expected from the great reader, when he has overstrained his eyes and the membranes of his brain; he is in a state of chronic mental headache, while the wise

bearing you onwards, prevent you from making any headway against it. It is only by rowing oneself that one goes forward; no current can take you to the point you aim at reaching. Go your own way and do not drift into the wake of everybody else.

What you must principally cut down is the less solid and serious kind of reading. There must be no question at all of poisoning your mind with novels. One from time to time, if you like, as a recreation and not to neglect some literary glory, but that is a concession; for the greater number of novels upset the mind without refreshing it; they disturb and confuse one's thoughts.

As to newspapers, defend yourself against them with the energy that the continuity and the in-

II

The principle of choice is already included in these first remarks. "What discernment we should exercise," said Nicole, "about the things that feed our mind and are to be the seed of our thoughts! For what we read unconcernedly today will recur to our minds when occasion arises and will rouse in us, even without our notice, thoughts that will be a source of salvation or ruin. God stirs up the good thoughts to save us; the devil stirs up the evil thoughts of which he finds the seed in us." [1]

[1] Nicole, *Essais de morale contenus en divers traités*, V.II, Paris 1733, p. 244.

that discoveries in thought are rare. The old stock or rather the permanent stock of ideas is the best; one must take one's stand on it in order truly to commune with the intelligence of man, far from petty, stammering, squabbling individualities.

It was a milliner (Mlle. Bertin) who aptly said: "There is nothing new but what is forgotten." The majority of writers only edit and publish other writers' thoughts: that is something, but the original author himself appeals to me.

Therefore, you will read with an open mind anything good that is written; you will take account of what is of present interest; you will take still more account of actuality in matters of information, of positive notions that are evolving or growing; for

again, "and the corruption of man taints most of his actions, and as it consists in ignorance and concupiscence, almost all books have something of these two faults." [1] Therefore it is often necessary in the course of one's reading to filter what one reads so as to purify it. For that, we must trust God and our better self, the self which is the child of God and in which an instinct for truth, a love of the good, will serve as a safeguard. But remember besides that the value of a book is partly your own value, and what you are capable of getting out of it. Leibnitz made use of everything; St. Thomas took from the heretics and the paganizers of his day an enormous number of thoughts, and none of

[1] *Op. cit.* p. 246.

we have just said; each kind has also its particular requirements. Fundamental reading demands docility, accidental reading demands mental mastery, stimulating reading demands earnestness, recreative reading demands liberty.

When one's mind is in process of formation and one has almost everything to learn, the hour has not come for individual initiative. Whether one is at the earlier stage, acquiring all-round culture, or taking up a new branch of study, a problem hitherto neglected, the authors consulted for this purpose must be believed rather than criticized, and followed in their own line of thought rather than used according to the reader's views. To launch out into action too soon interferes with the process

contrary, to give credence to the master and to be relatively passive, conceding to him something of what is due to truth, is to the advantage of truth itself, and enables the pupil at last to utilize even the deficiencies and illusions of the teacher. One only knows what a man lacks by estimating his wealth.

It is elementary wisdom beforehand to choose among a thousand the guides whom one will thus trust. The choice of an intellectual father is always a serious thing. We have advised St. Thomas for the highest doctrines. One cannot confine oneself to him; but all that is necessary is to know thoroughly three or four authors for one's specialty, and about the same number for each problem that

your own master and losing the benefits of formation offered you by one who could initiate you into his subject.

He who reads in view of a piece of work has his mind dominated by what he aims at doing; he does not dive into the water, he draws from it; he stands on the bank, preserves the freedom of his movements; he confirms his own idea at each borrowing instead of sinking it in the idea of another; and he lays down his book enriched, not dispossessed of what he brought to it—for that would happen if the fascination of the reading interfered with the purpose of utilizing it which was its justification.

With regard to stimulating reading, the choice,

Prayer of St. Thomas, by a chapter of the *Imitation* or by one of the parables. Each one should watch himself, note what helps him, keep at hand together his remedies for the sicknesses of the soul and not hesitate to go back and back to the same cordial or the same antidote until these have utterly lost their efficacy.

In the matter of reading for relaxation choice seems much less important. Relatively indeed it is so; but let no one imagine that it is all the same to find distraction in this or in that, when the object is to come back in the best of conditions to what is

[1] One of the most impressive of Bossuet's famous *Oraisons funèbres*. (Tr. Note.)

your fan.

Many thinkers have found habitual relief and attraction in stories of travel and exploration, in poetry, art criticism, reading of plays, memoirs. Each one has his tastes, and taste in this matter is the capital thing. One thing alone according to St. Thomas gives real rest: joy; to seek distraction in something boring would be a delusion.

Read something that you like, that does not excite you too much, that does not harm you in any way; and since even when you seek distraction you are leading the consecrated life, have the intelligence to read, among the books that are equally

1 In the French, *dévoyer,* literally turn from the path, turn astray. (Tr. Note.)

a nobler and more precious place to live in, it renews for each man the glory of being a man, of having his mind open on the same horizons as the greatest, of living on high levels and of forming with his fellows, with those who afford him inspiration, a society in God. "Next after men of genius come those who can recognize their worth," said Thérèse Brunswick, speaking of Beethoven.

To recall from time to time the names of those who shine with special brilliance in the firmament of the intelligence is to dip into the record of our titles to nobility; and this pride has the same beauty and efficacy as the pride that a son takes in an illustrious father or a great ancestry.

If you are a man of letters, do you not appreci-

intellectual life. To cultivate the faculty of admiration and because of it to keep constantly in familiar touch with illustrious thinkers, is the means, not of equalling those whom we honor, but of equalling our own best self; and that, I repeat, is the objective to be visualized and pursued.

Contact with writers of genius procures us the immediate advantage of lifting us to a higher plane; by their superiority alone they confer a benefit on us even before teaching us anything. They set the tone for us; they accustom us to the air of the mountaintops. We were moving in a lower region; they bring us at one stroke into their own atmosphere. In that world of lofty thought, the face of truth seems to be unveiled; beauty

Listen to certain Preludes of Bach. They do not say much; there is a short motif repeated; then insistent variations in no higher relief than that of a medal by Roty.[2] But what a level of inspiration! Into what an unknown world we are transported! To stay there and move freely in it would be our dream. We can at least go back there in memory, and what a blessing it is to be able to rise so far above futilities! It refines us, and helps us to pass a just judgment on the brilliant but foolish display of fireworks that often forms the staple of intellectual entertainments.

[1] Victor Hugo.

[2] An illustrious French sculptor and engraver, 1846-1911. (Tr. Note.)

to it. We cast on the inspired page an imploring glance that is not in vain; we are helped, paths are opened up to us; we are reassured, initiated; the work of God in rare minds is put to our account as well as to theirs; we grow through them; we are enriched through them; the giant carries the dwarf, and the ancestor offers us an inheritance. Shall we not profit by these resources? We can if we will. Attention and fidelity are all that is necessary.

Genius makes all things new for us. Genius is a seer, whose pre-eminent gift it is to present reality to our minds under an unsuspected light, in the heart of a connected system which is a sort of new creation—that reality which was there, obvious, and which we did not see.

as Leonardo da Vinci reduced to the synthesis of a single moment the changing expressions of his model. Genius is the Egyptian line applied to everything, and its rich simplicity furnishes forth our splendid display.

Genius stimulates us and gives us confidence. The stir it arouses is a spur to ardent personal endeavor, revealing a vocation, correcting over-anxious timidity. A sense of sublimity breaks on our soul like a sunrise. Wisdom, tried and proved in her heroes, has whispered an invitation to us too; and what happiness it is to say: She is in me also!

It is perhaps not true that great men reflect only their age; but it is true that they reflect humanity,

them have shadows, like a face with very marked features—the exaggeration of a point of view, or some other excess may carry them far from rectitude. Still, there is not one of them but in spite of aberrations leads a prepared mind to the eternal foundations of knowledge and the secrets of life.

Their errors are not vulgar errors, but excesses; in their very mistakes they are not without depth and keenness of vision; following them cautiously, one is sure to go a long way and one can avoid their blunders. "To them that love God, all things work together unto good," says the Apostle; for those who have a firm grasp of truth, everything can be useful. Having formed our mind under good teachers, keeping the framework of our thought

in error the mental development that, thanks to them, Providence provides for us.[1]

Think what the Church owes to heresies and philosophy to its great conflicts of opinion. If it had not been for Arius, Eutyches, Nestorius, Pelagius, Luther, Catholic dogma would not have been constituted. If Kant had not shaken the foundations of human knowledge, criteriology would still be in its childhood; and if Renan had not written on Christian origins, the Catholic clergy would be far from having the historical and exegetical formation they now possess.

What is true collectively is true individually. We must learn right thinking principally by contact

[1] St. Thomas, *In II. Metaphys. lect. I.*

disputes, but their work and what is lasting in it. It is futile to linger endlessly over differences; the fruitful research is to look for points of contact.

Here St. Thomas gives us an admirable example. He always tried to compare doctrines, to illustrate and complete them one by the other. He was an Aristotelian, but leaned also on Plato; without being an Augustinian he fed his mind constantly on Augustine; he who declared Averrhoes a corrupter of peripateticism, nevertheless calls him a sublime spirit (*praeclarum ingenium*), and quotes him constantly. When he comments on a passage, he interprets the text, if need be, so as to make it yield its purest content of truth or its greatest wealth of meaning, saying what we are to see in it, charitably

universal, it falls to the level of a spirit of clique and gossip.

It is not only on the doorsteps that we meet gossips; they are to be found in the history of philosophy, of the sciences, even of theology; and many people copy them. Rise above that. You who seek truth and are ready to recognize its countenance everywhere, do not set its servants up one against the other, even though they should be among those "incomplete angels," men of partial genius whom truth has visited without making its dwelling-place in them.

Especially in regard of very great minds it is a sort of profanation to adopt a fault-finding attitude. Let us regret their errors, but without violent

the arches they bear converge, and by means of many moldings they join to form a single roof. The fulfilment of your desire is to see that sheltering roof and to take refuge beneath it—you who are seeking not notoriety, nor the clash of parties, nor the spirit of discussion, nor artificial stimulation of the intelligence, but truth alone.

VI

One last and capital point has to be noted about reading. The reader, if in a certain way he must be passive in order to open his mind to truth and not to hinder its ascendency over him, is nevertheless called on to react to what he reads so as to make it his own and by means of it to form his

A man who is always listening may never learn, unless he changes into his own substance what he has heard in his docile intercourse with others. Docility is praiseworthy and necessary; it is not enough. "Obedience is at the foundation of progress," said Auguste Comte; but it is not progress. The man of genius who teaches us might say, like Him who inspires him: "I am come that they may have life and may have it more abundantly" (John 10:10). Will what was life in others be for us nothing more than a lamp whose light has died?

No one can teach us without our own effort. Reading puts truth before us; we have to make it ours. It is not the dealer in the market place who

[1] Alfred de Musset.

produces knowledge is not the system of signs put before us, it is the work of our own reason on those signs.

At bottom, the intellectual propositions that are put to us remain as much outside our intelligence as the things themselves that we want to know; they have only this advantage, that they correspond, as signs, to ideas already worked out and set in order. That facilitates our thought but does not take its place. All that teaching does is to provide us with means of mental activity, as medicine offers our bodies means of getting well; but just as

1 Boethius, *De Consolatione philosophiae,* V. prose 5.
2 St. Augustine, Opusculum *De Magistro.*

to the thought expressed and even beyond it, for an idea evoked in an active mind should always rouse some further idea.

We enter into the intimacy of genius only by sharing the same inspiration; to listen from outside is to condemn oneself not to hear. It is not with the eyes, nor with the ears, that one hears a great saying, it is with a soul on the level of what is revealed to it, with an intelligence illuminated by one and the same light.

The source of knowledge is not in books, it is in reality, and in our thought. Books are signposts;

1 St. Thomas, *De Magistro,* in the *Quaestiones disputatae de Veritate,* q.XI, art. I, with the arguments and answers.

German mind, said: "The Germans bring the bundles of wood to the woodpile; the French provide the sparks." That judgment is perhaps too absolute; but certainly it is the sparks that start the flame.

To develop wisdom was the first object of our education; it is still that of the education that we essay to provide for ourselves. Without wisdom, what we take in would be worthless, it would be as useless as was the first when it was on the library shelf. In ourselves also there are volumes and texts of great value that we do not read.

What an abuse it is to associate with great minds and to get from them nothing but formulas! And

all men's ancestor; wisdom addresses her invitation to all; we must not leave to the greatest the monopoly of making a superior use of what is offered us. Compared with men of genius we are only children, but we are children with an inheritance. What they give us is ours because it belongs to eternity; from eternity they themselves received it. We must contemplate, while they speak to us, what was before them and is above them, what God makes ready for us all.

It is on these conditions that we may attain originality; and we may count fully, if some day our wisdom grows, on doing original work in the true sense of the term. If we are to produce some-

does not make the least natural object without a purpose. I am obeying my Master by setting myself free. I am alive, I am not a mere reflection, and I want to live a fruitful life. Whatever engenders nothing is non-existent; my reading must enable me to engender thought in the likeness, not of the author who inspires me, but of myself!

That is, I think, the last word on the question of books. A book is a signal, a stimulant, a helper, an initiator—it is not a substitute and it is not a chain. Our thought must be what we ourselves are. When we read, our masters must not be a goal for us, but a starting-point. A book is a cradle, not a tomb. Physically we are born young and we die

you.

In fine, let us work with truth for our companion, with God for our companion. Our model is in the creative Thought. Men of genius are but a shadow. To be the shadow of a shadow is a poor thing for one, who, whether small or great, is here on earth a spiritual entity, incomparable, unparalleled, unique.

Man is multiple and each of us is a separate specimen of mankind; God is in all men; let us have the wisdom to honor man and to respect God in ourselves.

[1] A thought familiar to Abbé de Tourville, who applied it to social science.

faculty; but it is nevertheless certain that, other things being equal, a richly filled and tenacious memory is a precious resource.

Let us not conclude that we must exercise the memory indiscriminately and load our minds with the greatest possible number of notions, facts, images, passages from books. It might seem that St. Thomas recommends this, when he writes in his *Sixteen Precepts:* "Lay up in the treasury of your mind all that you can, like a man aiming at filling a vessel." We must understand this brief maxim with an implied reservation. We must remember everything that we can, on condition that it is useful, as with the same reservation we read everything we can.

to live. Engrave on your mind whatever can help you to conceive or carry out a project, whatever your soul can assimilate, whatever can serve your purpose, vivify your inspiration, and sustain your work. As for the rest, consign it to oblivion. And if it is possible that on occasion many things may be useful which did not seem likely to be so, and in fact are not usually so, that is not a reason for saying: let us remember them on the off-chance. If need be you will look them up again; they will easily be preserved on paper. On the pretext that you may have to catch any train, you do not learn the Railway Guide by heart.

Pascal said that he did not think he had ever forgotten a thing that he wanted to remember;

share in our vocation. Memory, like the mind itself, should specialize; in the same degree, with the same concentration on the principal object, and the same broad outlook on secondary matters.

There are things that everyone must know, that in particular every Catholic must keep in mind; there are things that an intellectual cannot afford to be ignorant of; there are others connected more or less closely with our special subject that each person will feel the need of possessing according to the breadth or narrowness of mind that he brings to them; lastly there are things essentially belonging to our special subject, without which we are beneath our task and properly accused of ignorance and culpable inertia.

in order to sanctify the memory by these divine words." [1] It is a way of setting the seal on the heavenly vocation common to all of us, and of facilitating our effort after good. Nowadays very few people understand such advice. A man will declaim long passages from Virgil, Racine, Musset, who would be hard put to it to recite a psalm, who does not know his *Angelus,* his *Salve Regina,* his *Te Deum,* or *Magnificat.* That is evidently out of order. What is riveted in our mind by memory has more effect on us; a Catholic must desire that effect to be greatest with regard to what enlivens his faith. It would help him so much if he could from time to time during the day or when occasion arises re-

[1] *Op. cit.* p. 261.

what connects this thing with that, what conditions are necessary for this and for that; let this coordination, and not scattered fragments, fix itself in your memory. A well-ordered mind is like a genealogical tree, in which all the branches spring from the trunk and so communicate with one another; relationships of every degree appear clearly in it, showing family descent in all its connections and as a whole.

That means that in memory, as in thought itself, we must bring everything into relation with what is essential. The primordial, the fundamental, the simple, whence complexity arises step by step and through successive *differences,* is what supports

expand with every progress, as the brain profits by food entering the stomach, the heart by the exercise of the limbs.

A new idea acts retrospectively; a torch throws its light behind as well as before. Materials that were laid aside take on a new aspect when they are classified by means of an idea. Then everything within us is reborn and animated with a new life. But for that to happen, the paths of light must be open, our thoughts must be in order and linked consecutively one with another.

When we have put order in mind and memory, we shall be almost automatically protected from excessive strain, and we shall notice that two ap-

habits of the silkworm; he asked some rather casual questions of the great entomologist Henri Fabre. Fabre was surprised at first at the apparent superficiality of the "Parisian"; but soon, seeing that Pasteur was going deeper and working on the very springs of life, he understood, and later he praised this singlemindedness of genius.

There are in every subject-matter a few ideas that govern the whole, that are keys to everything; there are some also that govern life, and before these we must light the sanctuary lamp within our hearts.

The creative faculty largely depends on the wisdom and controlled activity of the memory. A firm grip of what is essential leaves the outlook open

and it suffices, that he should set up in himself, thanks to memory, a corresponding structure which enables him to adapt himself and thereby to act.

III

It remains to say how such a memory can be acquired, and how it can be turned to account. That is not a very great secret, although it is bound up with the most fundamental conditions of the life of our mind.

St. Thomas proposes four rules: (1) To set in order what one wants to remember; (2) to apply the mind deeply to it; (3) to think over it often; (4) when one wants to recollect it, to take the chain of connections by one end, which will bring

exist in order to be preserved, and an element separated from its kindred elements only half exists.

So when you want to remember, notice the connections and the reasons of things; analyze them, look for the why and wherefore, observe the genealogy of happenings, their order of succession, and their dependent consequences; imitate the procedure of mathematics in which necessity starts from the axiom and arrives at the most distant conclusions. Fully to understand a thing, then to learn and to introduce into one's mind not frag-

1 *De Memoria et Reminiscentia,* Lect. 5.
2 *Ibid.,* Lect. 2.

exactly in as far as you want to fix it in your memory. If it is a book, do not leave it without being able to sum it up and to estimate its value. I add this last suggestion, because the object that has roused us to active intervention is much less fugitive; it has a link with our personality.

Next, a necessity following on the previous one is to reflect, as often as is possible and as is worthwhile, on the object to be preserved from oblivion. Life obliterates the traces of life, and for that reason we were advised to engrave deeply; the same motive urges us, seeing that nevertheless the traces grow dimmer, to run the tool over the lines again, to apply plenty of acid to the etching, that is, con-

between thoughts and impressions on which we have based the constitution of our memory. Everything is more or less linked together in the brain even without our willing it; when we have willed it with all our power and diligently established the most natural connections possible between notions, we shall reap the profit.

We must not then search at random in a whole which was not formed at random; we must proceed logically, utilizing the logic of things as it reveals itself inescapably or as we have conceived it in the beginning; going up or down the series we have formed, making use of contiguous ideas, of circumstances; in short, bringing back deliberately under

part it was to play, the book that had been analyzed or the work done. Starting from that point, I will explore in every direction, and by various efforts I will try to find what I know was linked with one or other of these circumstances.

To sum up, what matters about memory is not so much the number of things it retains, as, first, their quality, then their order, and lastly skill in using them. Materials are hardly ever lacking to thought; it is thought that is lacking to the materials. To learn is nothing at all without intelligent assimilation, orderly connection, the progressive unity of a rich and well-ordered soul.

What is interesting is not the workyard, it is the

at completing ourselves, so as to produce our work when the time comes.

We must read relatively little; we must remember very much less and anyhow nature sees to that. Notes, which are a sort of external memory, a "paper memory" Montaigne called them, must bear a very small proportion to reading; but they can cover more ground than memory, they can supply for it, and so take the strain off it and help our work in a measure that is hard to assign.

If we had to trust memory to keep intact and ready for use all that we have come upon or found out in the course of our life of study, it would be perfectly disastrous. Memory is an unreliable servant; it loses things, it buries them, it does not

We can distinguish two kinds of notes, corresponding to the remote and the immediate preparation for our work. You read or reflect in order to form and feed your mind; ideas occur that it seems good to fix in the memory; you come across facts, various indications, which may be useful later on; you note them down.

On the other hand, when you have to study a precise subject, to produce a definite piece of work, you try to gather material, you read what has been published on the question, you have recourse to all the sources of information at your disposal, you make your own reflections, and you do it all pen in hand.

Notes in the first category have the character of

by a sort of anticipatory discouragement from ever opening them. Their imaginary treasures have cost much time and trouble, and they yield no return; they are choked up by a vast number of worthless things; the useful ones might often with advantage have stayed in the tomes from which they were extracted, a reference with a rapid summary taking the place of wearisome pages.

Keep notes made after thinking, and with moderation. In order to avoid first-minute surprises, the effect of some passing preoccupation, or the enthusiasm sometimes aroused by a brilliant form of words, do not definitely include the passage in your notes without letting some time elapse. Quietly, at the right distance, you will judge of

Avoid caprice in everything. Just as reading is food, and memory a rich possession that becomes part of the personality, notes also are storehouses of nourishment and of personality. Reading, memory, notes should all complete us, should therefore be like us, have something of our self, our rôle, our vocation; they should correspond to what we are aiming at and to the form of external activity by which we can and will realize it.

Everyone knows how much an account book tells about its owner, his way of living and the objects he pursues; the notebooks and the pigeonholes should be just as closely related to the intellectual, to what he must be and wants to be; in them is his credit account, at least in part; and that account

more than I write down that other person's thought; and my ideal is that that should be true even if, not hoping better to express our common thought, I transcribe textually. A writer is a man who conceives an idea; but I also conceive whatever I assimilate profoundly, what I endeavor to penetrate, to comprehend in the full sense of the word, what I make my own; I am therefore the writer also, and I store the thing up as part of my own wealth.

As to notes taken remotely, there is nothing else essential to consider. Proximately, with a view to a particular work, we must intensify the application of our rules, and add another.

fixed on the stream of travellers among whom there is a friend.

Let your reading then be more and more influenced by a definite idea; let it take account not only of your vocation and your personality, but of their immediate application. Reading in that way has a set purpose; now, a set purpose is like a sieve which retains the desired grain and lets the rest slip through. Do not let your attention wander; do not linger by the way; have only your own objective before your eyes, without regard to that of the author which may be quite different. I venture to say, even though the expression has something repugnant about it and is almost always a warn-

used as they stand; you determine the ideas that you will have to develop, noting down only their principal characteristics if these present themselves; you record the precise expressions, the felicitous comparisons that occur to you; sometimes you develop a whole passage, not with the intention of completing it, but because it comes of itself and because inspiration is like grace, which passes by and does not come back.

When you think you have explored the whole ground, I mean as regards what you are aiming at or hoping for, your work is prepared; the workshop is full of materials of which some are quite in the rough, others provisionally shaped out. We shall speak presently of the work of construction;

but the matter is grasped, mastered, and you are sure that when the plan does emerge, it will correspond to a real conception, to ideas that you have, not to ideas that you are running after—that it will therefore be no arbitrary diagrammatic scheme, no system of compartments to be filled even though you may have nothing natural, spontaneous, and therefore really living to put into them.

Notes of this kind, notes of study, notes of inspiration cannot be made in odd moments; they are intense work, and it should be reserved for what we have called the moments of plenitude to look for them. Other notes, although they too require effort, will sometimes be of the nature of a happy find, will come by chance. But those will be

We must beware of a certain craze for collecting which sometimes takes possession of those who make notes. They want to have a full notebook or filing cabinet; they are in a hurry to put something in the empty spaces, and they accumulate passages as other people fill stamp and postcard albums. That is a deplorable practice; it is a sort of childishness, and risks becoming a mania. Order is a necessity, but it must serve us, not we it. To indulge obstinately in accumulating and completing is to turn one's mind away from producing and even from learning; excessive attention to classification interferes with use; now in this connection everything must be subordinated to the good of the work.

title, can be kept in a rack or cabinet; and each compartment will bear on the outside, if not the title which one may prefer not to display, at any rate a serial number corresponding to a table of contents that the worker will always have at hand.

But it seems by far the most practical method, for most kinds of work, to keep notes on slips. Have a supply of slips of fairly strong paper, of a uniform size that you will decide on according to the average length of your notes. There will be nothing to prevent you from continuing on a second slip the extract begun on the first. Your slips must be cut exactly, with a paper-cutter; any binder or printer will do it for you in five minutes; and besides there are special firms that will spare

Classification presupposes that you have adopted a carefully chosen method suitable to your work. Here we can only make general suggestions. Each person should draw up, if necessary, a catalog of subjects with divisions and subdivisions, about which he already has, or thinks that he must procure, notes. There is a very ingenious system, called the decimal system, applicable to every kind of research: I refer for its elucidation to a booklet that is interesting and very clear.[1]

If one fears complication, which is indeed a grave drawback, let each one fall back on his own practical ideas. In this matter we must be realists,

[1] *L'Organisation du Travail intellectuel,* by Dr. Chavigny, Fellow of the Val de Grâce. Delagrave, 1918.

said, two ways are open to you.

If you have a detailed plan, and if your notes have been made or sought with reference to it, number the successive headings of your plan. Number correspondingly (lightly in pencil if the notes are to be used again later) the slips that relate to them; put together the slips bearing the same numbers; insert each little bundle in a clip; sort out the bundles, and all you have then to do is to write, laying out before you in succession the contents of each bundle.

If, on the contrary, you have prepared your work without a settled plan, simply following general lines, you must now draw up your plan; you must extract it from the documents themselves. For that

search on these points; number with a number corresponding to each theme the slips referring to it; sort and clip as before, and your work is prepared.

ready are inseparable from a certain amount of production, which is helpful to them. One finds one's way only by taking it. All life moves in a circle. An organ that is used grows and gets strong; a strong organ can be used more effectively. You must write throughout the whole of your intellectual life.

In the first place one writes for oneself, to see clearly into one's personal position and problems, to give definition to one's thoughts, to keep up and stimulate attention which sometimes flags if not kept on the alert by activity—to make a beginning on lines of investigation which prove to be necessary as one writes, to encourage oneself in an effort that would be wearisome in the absence of

Père Gratry insists strongly on the efficacy of writing. He would like people always to meditate pen in hand; and to devote the untroubled morning hour to this contact of the mind with itself. We must take account of varying individual dispositions; but it is certain that for the majority of people, the pen as it runs plays the part of the trainer at games.

To speak is to listen to one's soul and to the truth within it. To speak alone and wordlessly, as one does by writing, is to listen and perceive truth with a freshness of sensation like that of a man who rises in the early morning and holds his ear to nature.

Everything must have a beginning. "The be-

cording as the writer himself is formed; silence is a diminution of the personality. If you want fully to exist from the intellectual point of view, you must know how to think aloud, to think explicitly, that is to shape both within you and for the outside world the word which is the expression of your mind.

Perhaps it is in place here to say briefly what style should be if it is to correspond to the aim we have been suggesting to the intellectual.

Alas! In order to venture to say how to write, one should oneself abstain. It is not difficult to be humble when one has fallen under the spell of a master style, or experienced the resulting sense of liberation and expansion in reading, say Pascal,

conventionality, what M. Bergson would call the "ready-made." To write with one part of one's being, to live one's sincere and spontaneous life with another, is an insult to the spoken word and to the harmonious unity of human nature.

The ceremonial discourse is the type of those things that are said because they have to be said, in which the thought is merely an effort at apt expression, an expenditure of that eloquence which is the laughingstock of genuine eloquence.[1] And indeed the ceremonial discourse is often but a mere

[1] One of Pascal's *Thoughts* which may be paraphrased: truly spontaneous and inspired eloquence mocks at the eloquence which is based on rules of rhetoric, has no need of or use for them. (Tr. Note.)

recognize itself in him, because it is human nature that has inspired the discourse. Life recognizes life. If I give my neighbor just black marks on white paper, he will perhaps look at the thing curiously, but then he will throw it down; if I am like a tree offering foliage and fruit full of rich sap, if I give my whole self, I will convince him, and like Pericles, leave the dart in men's souls.

If I obey the laws of thought, I cannot but show myself in close contact with things, or rather in the heart of things. Thinking is conceiving what is; writing truly, that is writing according to one's thought, is revealing what is, not stringing sentences together. And so the secret of writing is to stand and study things ardently, until they speak

tion of the idea.

As Paul Valéry observes, it is automatic use that kills languages. We are alive, he says, when we use syntax "with full consciousness," taking trouble watchfully to bring out every element, avoiding certain effects that arise of themselves and obtrusively claim priority. That claim is precisely the reason for turning away these parasites, these intruders, these unwanted visitors.

Greatness of style consists in discovering the essential links between the elements of thought and in expressing them with an art that completely excludes every tentative approximation. What an ideal [1] that is which Emerson formulates, to write

[1] Quoted in the biography by Régis Michaud.

have picked up, behind traditional phrases, word combinations that merely represent old habits and not our own ardor of conviction. To show our mind as it is, basing ourselves on acquired habits of expression common to all, but not losing ourselves in them, would be to rouse inexhaustible interest, and it would be art.

The style that suits a mind is like the body that belongs to a soul, or the plant that grows from a particular seed; it has its own proper structure. To imitate is to forego your thought; to write without character is to declare it vague or puerile.

One should never write "in the manner of" so-and-so, even if the so-and-so were oneself. One

everything it touches, but self-assertiveness setting itself up against the sway of truth.

Simplicity of style results from these principles. Embellishment is an offense against thought, unless it be an expedient to conceal its void. There are no embellishments in the real; there are only organic necessities. Not that there is no brilliance in nature; but the brilliance itself is organic, it has its rightful existence, it is supported by substructures that never break down.

In nature, the flower is as important a thing as the fruit, and the foliage as the branch; the whole springs from the roots and is but the manifestation of the germ which holds within itself the idea of

[1] A French philosopher, 1832-1918. (Tr. Note.)

as expert in writing as an old blacksmith at his iron work; but the blacksmith does not amuse himself twisting his metal into ornamental curves, he makes bars, locks, gates.

Style excludes everything useless; it is strict economy in the midst of riches; it spends whatever is necessary, saves in one place by skillful arrangement, and lavishes its resources elsewhere for the glory of the truth. Its rôle is not to shine, but to set off the matter; it must efface itself, and it is then that its own glory appears. "The beautiful is the removal of all superfluity," said Michelangelo, and Delacroix points out in him "the big settings, the simple cheek lines, the noses broadly drawn." He notes that such a style can only fit in with very

simplification: that is the secret of strength. The masters end by repeating only that which St. John repeated: "Love one another." The innocent nudity which reveals the splendor of living forms—thought and reality, creations and manifestations of the Word—is the law and the prophets in the matter of style.

Unfortunately this bare purity of the mind is rare; when it does exist it is often allied with empty-headedness. And so only two kinds of mind, the mind of limited power and the mind of genius, seem predisposed to simplicity; the others have to acquire it laboriously, cumbered by their possessions, and unable to limit themselves at their will.

[1] Gratry, *Les Sources.*

We have seen that it is not enough to work with the intelligence alone: the whole man is necessary. But the man who engages in the work must not be the creature of passion, vanity, ambition, or vain desire to please.

Everyone is passionate at times, but passion must at no moment get the upper hand. Everyone is inclined to vanity, but it is a vice if the work itself at bottom is vanity. The important thing is not what we shall get out of knowledge, but what we can give to it. The essential thing is not the reception accorded to our words, but the reception that we ourselves have given to truth, and that we are disposing others to give to it. Of what weight, in view of that sacred purpose, are our petty selfish

Whoever wants something for himself sets truth aside: the jealous God will not sojourn with him. We must work, we said, in a spirit of eternity; what is less eternal than an ambitious aim? You are consecrated to truth, you must serve, not use it.

One throws oneself wholeheartedly only into causes that one would die for. Are you ready to die for the truth? Everything that a real lover of truth writes, everything that he thinks should be like the letters that St. Peter Martyr traced with the blood of his wound as he was dying: *Credo.*

The selfish personality lessens every value that it touches; it contaminates everything, cheapens everything, it disorganizes our powers. The man

1 A very great French tragic actor, 1763-1826. (Tr. Note.)

to the suggestions of pride. One wants to keep one's secret; one hides one's lack of competence; one poses as big, knowing oneself to be little; one "asserts," "declares," "is sure"; at bottom one does not know; one imposes on the public; and, half-duped by one's own game, one deceives oneself.

Another fundamental fault is to affect in our thought that pseudo-originality that a moment ago we condemned in style. It is intolerable pride to try to force truth into our personal mold, and it ends in stupidity. Truth is essentially impersonal. When it borrows our voice and our mind it will take the color of our personality without any effort of ours: it will do this all the more that we are not thinking about ourselves: but to exert

farther away from the reader a book is written the more powerful it is," said Père Gratry in *Les Sources,* and he gives as examples Pascal's *Thoughts,* Bossuet's writings for the Dauphin, above all the *Summa* of St. Thomas of Aquin; a comparison between the *Petit Carême*[1] and the *Discours synodaux* of Massillon confirms the statement. It is true and Vauvenargues[2] agrees when

1 *Petit Carême,* Lenten sermons preached before the court. In them, says Gratry, the preacher "really goes too far in drawing out his thought: the web is so delicate as to weary the eye"; while the Synodal Addresses, "almost improvised for a few country priests in Auvergne," are "living energetic pages." (Tr. Note.)

2 A well known French moralist, author of a book entitled *Maximes* (1746). (Tr. Note.)

not be your own work if anxiety to please and to adapt yourself to others enslaves your pen. The public will then be thinking for you whose duty it was to think for it.

Seek the approval of God; be intent only on truth, for yourself and others; do not be a slave; make yourself worthy to say with Paul: "The word of God is not bound."

This virtue of independence is so much the more necessary as the public, in the mass, has all the qualities needed to pull you down. The public has the elementary school mentality. In most circles and by the majority of its votes it proclaims conventions, not truths; it likes to be flattered; it fears above everything to have its quietude disturbed.

be the measure of your fall.

This perverse world loves, at bottom, only saints; this cowardly world dreams of heroes; Roger Bontemps [1] grows grave and has thoughts of conversion when he sees an ascetic. In such a world you must not yield to public opinion and write as if humanity were looking over your shoulder. You must shake yourself free of other people, as well as of yourself. In the intellectual domain as in every other, to rise above man is to prepare wondrous things, for it is opening the way to the Spirit.

Seated at your writing table and in the solitude in which God speaks to the heart, you should listen

1 An easy-living, happy-go-lucky person: the surname of an old French poet popularized by Béranger. (Tr. Note.)

which bears difficulties well; perseverance which prevents the will from flagging.

"You must not imagine," says Nicole, "that the life of study is an easy life. . . . The reason is that there is nothing more against nature than uniformity and stillness, because nothing gives us more occasion to be alone with ourselves. Change and external occupations take us out of ourselves and distract us by making us forget ourselves. Moreover, this medium of words has always something dead about it, it has nothing that piques our self-love or rouses our passions strongly.[1] It is de-

1 Nicole, a 17th century moralist, was thinking of the carefully chastened and clarified language of "classical" French. (Tr. Note.)

the time, and we intend others to recognize the fact. People will know what we are by our way of resting, of idling, of tying our shoes: still more will it be evident in our fidelity to work, in our prompt and regular return to our task, and in its continuity.

When Edison was asked one day to say to a

1 Nicole *op. cit.*, page 255.

2 *Divertissement:* literally, the word means *turning aside* from ourselves and our destiny to find distraction in occupations, amusements, etc. "The whole calamity of man" (wrote Pascal) "comes from one single thing, that he cannot keep quiet in a room." That is the cause of all our misfortunes; and if we look for the reason of this restlessness we shall find that there is an effectual one, the craving to evade the vision of our destiny. (Tr. Note, taken from Jacques Chevalier.)

ing the work or touching it up, for verifying references, looking up notes, sorting papers, etc. That would be so much out of the way for the hours of really serious application, and the moments so turned to account would be as useful as the others, because these secondary tasks belong to the work and are indispensable to it.

Even during real working hours, there is a temptation to interrupt our effort as soon as the slightest happening brings back the "weariness" and rouses the "distaste" of which Nicole spoke. The ruses of sloth are endless, like those of children. Looking for a word that will not come, one begins to sketch something on the margin of the paper and the drawing must be finished. Opening the dictionary,

difficulties. All workers bewail the moments of depression that break in on the hours of ardor and threaten to bring their results to nothing. When the disgust with work lasts long, one feels that one would rather plant cabbages than pursue a wearisome study; one envies the laborer who on his side calls you a good-for-nothing because you sit quietly in your chair. What danger there is of giving up when you are in this distressing state of mind!

It is most of all at turning-points in our study that we must look out for sudden or insidious attacks of this kind. In every work there are troublesome transitions; to make one part follow closely on another is the great difficulty in study and

to pull yourself together. Nervous exhaustion would lead you nowhere. Possible remedies for fatigue are, for example, reading a few pages of a favorite author, reciting something aloud, kneeling down and saying a prayer so as to modify the state of the organism and therefore more or less refresh the mind, a few rhythmical movements or breathing exercises in the open air. Then get back to your effort.

Some people have recourse to stimulants; but that is a fatal method. The effect is only momentary; it grows less with use; the quantity has to be increased daily; and the progression ends in physical and mental degeneracy.

Walking, whether in the open air or in one's

walking excursion, it often happens that the first steep ascent finds you inert and breathless; your limbs ache; you are almost inclined to give up and go home. But if you keep on, the joints grow supple, the muscles act freely, the chest expands and you feel the delight of activity. It is the same with study. You must not yield to the first sense of fatigue; you must push on; you must force the inner energy to reveal itself. Little by little the mechanism gets into play, you adapt yourself, and a period of enthusiasm may follow on the first painful inertia.

Whatever be the cause of your difficulties you must go through them without flinching, keeping your self-mastery. Each spell of work is like a race-

memory for the subject always before your mind; if you are inclined to be scatterbrained, you attain the degree of attention of a professional; if you have little aptitude for distinguishing ideas, your judgment grows keener and surer by persevering contact with great thinkers. In every subject-matter, after a certain number of efforts to start, your motor warms up, and the road flies past.

Amiel one day asked himself in his Journal: "Why are you weak? Because times without number you have given in. So you have become the plaything of circumstances. It is you who have made them strong, not they who have made you weak."

Learn constancy by persistent application and by

depend but little on the will; when it refuses its service, what is to be done? When the threads of knowledge grow tangled and the hours go by in vain, when a painful feeling of powerlessness takes hold of you and there is not the least sign that this trial will soon end, where are you to turn and what help can you call on but the help of God?

When you succeed your reader will think it all quite simple; he will criticize your weaknesses without mercy; he will not suspect the cost of the work. But indeed he must not be allowed to suspect it. "Creations realized at the price of a great deal of work," said Michelangelo, "must in spite of the truth appear easy and effortless. . . . The great rule is to take much trouble to produce things that seem

When you feel yourself defenseless, overcome; when the road stretches out before you interminably, or when, having no doubt mistaken your direction, you have the impression of being lost, completely astray, wrapped in a thick fog, then is the time to draw on stores of energy held in reserve. Persist, stand up to the difficulty, be patient in the great sense of the word, which calls up the Passion of the Master. Ardor is easier than patience but both are necessary and success is the reward of their combination.

To the alpinist walking through a cloud it seems as if the universe were plunged in night; he goes on and he finds the sunlight beyond. In a closed room in bad weather, the elements outside seem

The soul is that secret spring: do not try prematurely to clear up its mystery. The stores of time belong to God; little by little He doles them out to us; but it is not our part to demand them or to grow impatient. Nothing is precious but what comes at the right moment.

Avoid the fuss and flurry of the man who is pressed for time. Hasten slowly. In the realm of mind, quietness is better than speed. There more than elsewhere the proverb is verified: All things come to him who waits. "A well-filled life is long," said Leonardo da Vinci. To the man who takes his time belongs all duration, itself situate in eternity. Work then in a spirit of eternity. Do not confuse

1 Friedrich Nietzsche, *So sprach Zarathustra.*

Niagara, does one long to see it hurry? Intellectual activity has its own worth at every stage. Effort is a virtue and a conquest. He who works for God and as God wills abides in God. What does it matter if time runs on, when one is established in God?

The consummation of steady constancy and patience is perseverance, which completes the work. "He that shall persevere unto the end, he shall be saved," says the Gospel. Intellectual salvation has no other law. "No man putting his hand to the plow and looking back" is worthy, in the intellectual order either, of the kingdom of heaven.

How many workers have given up plowing and sowing, and foregone the harvest! The whole world

of superiority. They end like a glorious day. The red light of the setting sun is no less beautiful than the first golden gleams of morning and it has grandeur in addition. The man of character who has worked unfailingly throughout a long life can go down like the sun into a quiet and splendid death; his work follows him, and at the same time remains to us.

You who walk in the footsteps of the great, be not of the number of those cowardly wayfarers who desert—who go a stage, stop, lose the way, sit down as if exhausted and go back sooner or later to the trodden places. You must hold out to the end of the journey. "Fair and softly goes far in a

of the line of faithful thinkers. The giants of work, such men as Aristotle, Augustine, Albert the Great, Thomas of Aquin, Leibnitz, Littré, Pasteur, will acknowledge you for their son; and you will go worthily to meet Him who is patiently waiting for you.

IV

If the requirements of these three virtues are satisfied there is little fear that the result will be mediocre or imperfect. However it is a good thing to insist strongly on the necessity of perfecting, and on the duty of bringing to completion, whatever one has thought well of undertaking.

want to make of your past a field of debris?

There are some people on whom one can count; when they promise they keep their word. Now every beginning is a promise, unless it is a piece of folly. Others give their word, swear by all they hold sacred, and nothing happens; you would think that they have some natural inaptitude for undertaking an obligation; you cannot bind them and they cannot bind themselves; they are like running water.

People like that represent a morally inferior species; the intellectual who resembles them is not really an intellectual, his vocation has condemned itself. You who have the sacred call, make up your mind to be faithful. There is a law within you, let it be obeyed. You have said: "I will do this," do it.

that in which I refuse to aim at the best. What is not perfected *is* not. According to Spinoza, being and perfection correspond to the same idea; being and good are convertible.

It is related of Titian that he sketched his pictures boldly, worked them up to a certain point and then put the painting against the wall until it had become like a stranger to him. Then he took it up again, and viewing it with a "hostile eye," he obliged it to turn into a masterpiece.

When you have roughed out a piece of work, you must put it aside like that, rest your eyes and look at it from a proper distance. If you do not approve of it then, start afresh. If it comes up to your level, critize it minutely, in every detail, and

life, which as a whole is sacred to the God of Truth, is His in every separate occurrence of which it is made up. In each work say to yourself: it is my duty to do it, and therefore to do it well, since what is not finished *is* not. In as far as I do it badly, I am missing my life, disobeying the Lord, and failing my brethren. In so far, I am unfaithful to my vocation. To have a vocation is to be obliged to perfection.

An important bit of practical advice is in place here. When you have decided on a work, when you have clearly conceived and carefully prepared it, and are actually beginning: settle *immediately* by a vigorous effort the quality that it is to have. Do not count on going back over it. When laziness

mental lines. The effort had already been made: he was only consummating it.

Therefore put out your very best at the moment of creation. When you have brought forth the work, you will treat it like the child that one feeds and educates, but whose heredity is fixed, whose fundamental characteristics are established. That will be the moment to apply to the offspring of your spirit the saying of the Bible: "He that spareth the rod hateth his son." (Prov. 13:24.)

V

All this severity with ourselves presupposes that the work undertaken is suited to us and proportioned to our resources. If the prey is more power-

particular work. And that is the point we now desire to make.

Try to discern in every occurrence the effort that befits you, the discipline you are capable of, the sacrifice you can make, the subject you can deal with, the thesis you can write, the book that you can read with profit, the public you can serve. Take the measure of all these things with humility and confidence. If need be, ask for advice, but do not forget that irresponsibility and indifference are widespread amongst advisers. Make up your mind to the best of your ability. Then throw yourself with your whole heart into your task.

Every work is great when it is in exact measure. A work that exceeds its proper limits is the least of

he breaks faith with the world; he is a flame that has gone out.

Success in every order is always attained on the same conditions: to reflect at the start, to begin at the beginning, to proceed methodically, to advance slowly, to give out all one's strength. But the first object of initial reflection is to decide what we are fit for. The "Know thyself" of Socrates is not only the key to morality, but to every vocation, since to be called to something is to see our individual path marked out along the wide human road.

more and say: Keep your soul free. What matters most in life is not knowledge, but character; and character would be endangered if a man were under his work, so to speak, struggling with Sisyphus' stone. There is a knowledge other than that which is of the domain of memory: the knowledge of how to live. Study must be an act of life, must serve life, must feel itself impregnated with life. Of the two kinds of men, those who endeavor to know something, and those who try to be someone, the palm is to the second. What we know is like a beginning, a rough sketch only; the man is the finished work.

It is certainly true that intellectuality contributes to the sovereignty of man; but it is not enough. Besides morality, which includes the life of religion,

man.

Pascal refuses his esteem to the specialist who is only a specialist; he does not want a man's book to be remembered the moment he comes into a room. "It is a bad mark," he says, and he does not mean it only from the point of view of comparative study which we have advocated; he is thinking of a harmonious human whole.

We must always be more than we are; the philosopher must be something of a poet, the poet something of a philosopher; the craftsman must be poet and philosopher on occasion, and the people recognize this fact. The writer must be a practical man, and the practical man must know how to write. Every specialist is first of all a person, and the

back to its work, it brings capacity for a new flight.

We have already quoted this saying of a rabbi: "Into a bushel full of nuts one can pour in addition many measures of oil"; we then applied it to studies which help one another instead of being in conflict. By the nuts let us now understand specialized work; one can add to it the oil of effortless intellectual life, leisure nobly employed, nature, art; all this does not overload the mind but, on the contrary, eases its strain.

The specialized work itself will be the gainer. It gains richly from society, friendships, external action: I have explained why. Here I am only expanding the conclusions we have reached, for they have a general bearing. Do you imagine that any

mountains steady our thoughts with their mass; and the course of the running streams starts the mind on lofty meditations.

I know a man who at the sight of a rapid mountain torrent inevitably thought of the movement of worlds—those masses that rush through space with the same speed, under the governance of the same laws, depending on the same forces, thanks to the same God with whom everything begins and to whom everything returns. Going back to his work he felt himself uplifted by the unique Force, filled with the Presence that is everywhere; and his obscure activity was rooted in communion with all being.

Yet you let your mind get cramped and your

ment, or a vivid image? The harmony has heightened the tone of his inspiration, and the rhythm in which he is caught up like a passerby in a troop of soldiers on the march, has carried him away on new paths.

At Saint Sulpice, painting the Chapel of the Angels, Delacroix revelled in the sound of the great organ and in the chanting; to that harmony he attributed the extraordinary success of his Jacob wrestling, and of the rider in the *Heliodorus*.

Music has this precious quality for the intellectual that as it conveys no precise ideas, it interferes with none. It awakens states of soul, from which each one in his particular task will draw what he wills. Rodin makes a statue of it, Corot a

One is a poor thing all by oneself in one's study! It is true one can bring the universe into it and people it with God; but that divine inhabitation is effective only after long experience, of which the elements are everywhere about us. Should I write under the impression of nature and of universal beauty, if great scenery, the peaceful countryside, the vision of the achievements of art, had not previously educated me?

We must widen our work in that way, in order not to be like the chained galley slave, or to turn intellectuality into an instrument of torture. Work is a free act.

You, therefore, who intend to devote yourself to

natural beauty; his mind shows itself to be one in everyday occupations and in meditation: he is the same man in the presence of God, of his fellows, and of his maid, carrying within him a world of ideas and feelings that are not only written down in books and in discourses, but flow into his conversation with his friends, and guide his life.

At bottom, everything is connected and everything is the same thing. Intellectuality admits of no compartments. All the objects of our thought are so many doors into the "secret garden," the "wine cellar" which is the goal of ardent research. Thoughts and activities, realities and their reflections, all have one and the same Father. Philos-

ject to the human rule which is confirmed by the law of God.

Nothing must be in excess. Work, precisely because it is a duty, requires limits which maintain it in full vigor, make it lasting, and enable it to yield in the course of life the greatest total effect of which it is capable.

Intemperance is a sin because it destroys us; and we have the obligation to use life wisely because we have the obligation to live. Now it is not only in coarse enjoyments that we can fall into intemperance; the subtlest and the noblest delights can partake of its harmful character. To love truth at the expense of prudence—that is, at the expense of the truth of life—is an absurdity. It proves that in

recover our energy.[2]

The man engaged in contemplation is "heavier than air": he can keep aloft only by a considerable expenditure of force: in a short time the supply of gas is exhausted and he must "fill up" again.

We can accept without paradox this saying of Bacon, which the discoveries of physiology corroborate: "To spend too much Time in Studies is Sloth." It is sloth directly, in as much as it is incapacity to overcome a fixed habit, to put on the brake sometimes. It is sloth indirectly because to refuse to rest is implicitly to refuse an effort that rest would render possible, and that overwork will

[1] *De Musica*, c. II.
[2] Cf. St. Thomas, 2a 2ae, qu. 168, art. 2.

The best way of all to relax would be, if possible, not to get tired; I mean, so to balance one's work that one operation would afford rest from another. In medicine, the effects of a harmful drug are often counteracted by its opposite. Not everything causes the same kind of fatigue, nor at the same moment. The puddler perspiring at his furnace would find it a rest to stack hay in the open country, and the man who stacks the hay to distribute it in the mangers.

We have already made some suggestions on this point. In speaking of the use of time, and then apropos of constancy in work, we touched on the principle of dividing up one's tasks. Not everything in intellectual work involves exhausting con-

not take takes itself: it steals into the work, under the form of distractions, of sleepiness, of necessary things that demand attention, not having been foreseen at the right time.

I am in the full swing of creative effort: I lack a reference; there is no ink in the bottle; I have forgotten to sort my notes; a book, a manuscript that I want are in another room, or buried under a pile from which they must be dug out. An hour ago all that would have been done easily, joyously, looking forward to the quiet hour that I was getting ready for. Now it disturbs me; my creative impulse dies. If I omitted these preparations because of some nominal work, some inferior occupation that I was bent on through lack of self-control,

communion with nature, some art accessible to us, some not tiring manual work, an intelligent stroll about town, theatrical performances that are not too exacting or too exciting, sport in moderation; these are our means of relaxation.

But they must not be carried to excess either. Protracted relaxation, besides eating up time, interfers with the momentum of a life of work. It is very important for each person to discover the harmonious alternation which leaves this momentum at its maximum with the minimum of fatigue. To work too long is to get worn-out; to stop too soon is to fail in giving one's measure. In the same way, to rest too long is to destroy the momentum acquired; to rest too little is to fail in renewing one's

categorical imperative was surely not conceived in a meadow, still less the so-called moral arithmetic of a Bentham.

To each young man who aspires to the heights and wants to go far, I say, keep within the reality of human nature. Secure yourself some leisure; do not exhaust yourself; work in tranquillity and in spiritual joy; be free. Use wiles with yourself if necessary; promise yourself in the moment of effort some pleasant relief of which the thought alone will refresh your mind until the moment comes when the actual pleasure will renew your energy.

If you form a group, be considerate about one another's relaxations. St. Thomas says that the man who never jests, who does not take a joke and does

"Superiority has to face so many obstacles and to endure so much suffering," wrote George Sand apropos of Balzac, "that the man who fulfils the mission of talent with patience and gentleness is a great man." You will not take the last word to yourself; but if in any degree you become someone, you must expect rare trials and be prepared to taste to the full their different qualities: the trial of the ideal which appears further off the more eagerly you strive to reach it; the trial of fools who do not understand a word of what you say and take scandal at it; the trial of jealous rivals who consider you impudent because you have passed beyond their line of battle; the trial of the good who

1 2a 2ae qu. 168, art. 4.

sin; it lifts us into a high region where the vexations of life and the weaknesses of the body find alleviation. The urge it rouses, the direction it gives to our energy, are an anodyne for worry and release us from wretched preoccupations.

If you are idle and investigate your body, you will probably feel a good deal of vague discomfort of various kinds; work energetically and you will forget it all. We can say the same about the troubles of the soul. When I ask myself what remedy I shall use against the fits of anxiety and dullness that come over me in my work, I find only one answer: work. What stimulus can I find for my courage, if I lose heart about my work? Work. What means have I of resisting those who are

sense of victory springing from work combats such depression; the expenditure of our powers in an orderly rhythm tones them up and regularizes them, giving them something of the spirit of the boat's crew which sings while rowing.

Truth is another defense; it steadies and strengthens us; it gives us delight; in its company we are consoled for our own shortcomings and those of others; its discovery is a reward, its manifestation a noble vengeance on days of contradiction.

The worker is exposed, among other annoyances, to that which is perhaps most keenly felt by the intellectual, and even by the man: criticism does not spare him. When the criticism is super-

of a crusade of children.

To correct one's mistakes and to keep silence is the great maxim; those who have practiced it have always risen to the heights; they turned the force that aimed at pulling them down into a forward impetus to victory; with the stones cast at them they built their dwelling.

It is childish to defend one's work or to try to establish its worth. Worth defends itself. The solar system does not intervene to settle the dispute between Ptolemy and Copernicus. Truth *is;* true works share in its being and in its power. To fuss and be disturbed about them weakens you. Be silent; humble yourself before God; distrust your

[1] *Journals,* Vol. VIII, p. 171.

error, and the noble purpose of utilizing the ill-will that God puts at your service. For evil itself is in the hands of God, and ill-natured criticism, because it is the sharpest, can turn most to your profit.

Having thus drawn your advantage from it, leave the rest to the Lord who judges for you and will do justice in His good time. Do not listen any further. "People do not speak ill," writes St. Augustine, "before the man who does not listen." Envy is a tax levied on the income of glory, distinction, or work. Work, invulnerable in itself, demands its price from the worker. Let him pay and not complain. "Great souls suffer in silence," says Schiller.

When there is nothing to be gotten out of an at-

among intellectuals; but a tacit classification none the less puts its seal on real values, even if they are not publicly acknowledged.

If you have to defer your usefulness also until later on—who knows? perhaps until you are no longer in this world—be satisfied; posthumous honor is the most disinterested, and posthumous utility is a sufficient fulfilment of the real purposes of your work. What do you desire? Vain glory? Profit? Then you are but a pseudo-intellectual. Truth? It is eternal. There is no need for eternity to be turned to utility.

Truth is revealed little by little; those who bring it out of the shadow have not the right to ask it to make them a halo; they serve, that is enough; to

none of these things disappoints one who believes and hopes; and they are even a happiness for one who loves, because love is better proved when one works for the pleasure of work, for the pleasure of the beloved and of his service.

IV

However, there are other things in work besides vexations; it has its joys; and it is a happy thing when joy alone disposes us to work and affords us relaxation after our effort.

We ought to be joyous even in afflictions and contradictions, after the example of the Apostle: I exceedingly abound with joy in all our tribulation. Sadness and doubt kill inspiration; but they

of the object and the love of knowledge as an act of life; it ends in the joy of ideal possession and of the ecstasy it causes.[2]

The Catholic intellectual has chosen renunciation; but renunciation enriches him more than proud opulence. He loses the world, and the world is spiritually given to him; he sits on the throne from which the twelve tribes of Israel are judged. (Luke 22:30.) His reality is the ideal; it replaces the other reality and swallows up its blemishes in beauty. Detached from everything in spirit, and very often literally poor, he grows by all that he gives up or that gives him up, for hiddenly he

[1] *In Psalm.* XXVI.
[2] 2a 2ae, qu. 180, art. 1. See pp. ix, 31, 133.

reward of effort is to have grown by it.

It is an astonishing thing that the true intellectual seems to escape those sad effects of age that are death before their time to so many men. He remains young up to the end. One would think that he had a share in the eternal youth of the true. He generally matures early, and is still mature, neither soured nor spoilt, when eternity gathers him in.

This exquisite lasting quality is also found in the saints; it would suggest that sanctity and intellectuality are of the same essence. Indeed, truth is the holiness of the mind; it preserves it; as holiness is the truth of life and tends to fortify it for this world and for the next. There is no virtue without

assuring whoever fulfils the conditions that he will attain the results he desires? One cannot promise anything to one who has not the necessary gifts. But presupposing the vocation, we have the right to say that cultivation of the mind is not principally the result of genius; it springs from work—properly so-called, organized, and sustained, as we have tried to describe it.

Work creates its instrument for itself. Like the blacksmith who tempers his tools, it forms our character and gives us solidity and therefore confidence.

This confidence which is founded on a natural law is attached to the work rather than to the worker; however the worker also must have faith

self. Besides we may expect a permanent contribution to our resources from those who initiate us into intellectual work, from our friends, and from our fellow-workers. We have the men of genius on our side. Great men are not great for themselves alone; they bear us up; our confidence is implicitly grounded on their existence. With their help, we can make for ourselves a life as great as theirs, except for the disproportion between our powers and theirs. The true intellectual need not fear sterility, inutility: it is enough that a tree be a tree to bear its seed. Results sometimes come late, but they come. The soul gives a return; events give a return. If we cannot rise to the height of what we

is finer for me, and there is no other similar.

I add this also, which is among our motives for confidence: when fidelity is asked of us, and persistent and well-ordered work, this is not meant completely to exclude every lapse; promises made under such a condition would be a mockery. To err is human; but if we hold habitually to what is essential in the prescriptions laid down, that is the sum total about which we are told that it is enough; but that it is indispensable.

It would be desirable that our life should be a flame without smoke or ashes, that no part of it should be lost, that nothing in it should be impure. That cannot be; but what is possible is a fine

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